



Hindustan Times

Nepal toll nears 800 as rising waters hamper rescue efforts

Reuters

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CHITWAN/BEIJING: Rescuers in Nepal and China raced on Sunday to find thousands of people missing after a glacier collapse unleashed a catastrophic mudslide across the Himalayas, as they faced challenging weather conditions and rising water levels.

Authorities said the death toll rose to nearly 800 on Sunday, with more than 3,000 people missing on both sides of the Nepal-China border after a torrent of ice, rock, mud and debris swept through mountain valleys and rivers on Wednesday, causing widespread devastation.

The ministry of external affairs meanwhile said 149 Indians have been rescued amid the ongoing relief operations.

The Red Cross has estimated that more than 90,000 people are likely to have been affected by the disaster, which China has linked to the effects of climate change.

Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi told his Nepalese counterpart during a Saturday telephone call that the mudslide was their "most severe cross-border disaster" in recent years and that rescue operations had risen to an unprecedented level of difficulty and complexity, state broadcaster CCTV reported.

Nepal's disaster authority said 781 people had died, with 2,502 missing. On the Chinese side, authorities said 16 people were killed in Gyirong County and 546 were missing.

The scale of the disaster has complicated rescue efforts across the rugged Himalayan terrain.

Local police in Nepal told Reuters on August 27, killing the trainee pilot and the instructor.

continued on →7



Damaged buildings next to a roaring Likhu River in Nuwakot district of Nepal on Sunday.

REUTERS

261 FOREIGNERS, INCLUDING 49 INDIANS, MISSING IN TIBET: CHINA

BEIJING/TRISHUL: China on Sunday said 261 foreign nationals, of whom 49 are Indians, were missing on the Tibetan side of a border crossing with Nepal following Wednesday's mudslide. Officials from China's Tibet Autonomous Region said that the most were from Nepal (104), while 49 Indian, 33 Latvian, 18 American and 15 British citizens were also unaccounted for. →5

High-risk glacial lakes in India under spotlight

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NEW DELHI: More than 200 glacial lakes in the Indian Himalayas have been flagged for either high-risk assessment or intensified monitoring in separate government assessments, bringing renewed focus to the country's mountain hazards after the devastating flash floods in Nepal.

The National Disaster Man-

agement Authority (NDMA) has identified 195 vulnerable glacial lakes across six Himalayan states and Union territories, including 67 classified as Category A, or "very high risk". Separately, the Central Water Commission, in its monitoring report for June 2026, flagged 147 glacial lakes that recorded an increase in water spread during the month and said they required vigorous monitoring. →5

DGCA reiterated Tecnam aircraft safety concerns before UP crash



The wreckage of the Tecnam plane that crashed in Kanpur on August 27, killing the trainee pilot and the instructor.

LUCKNOW: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) flagged safety concerns over aircraft made by Italian manufacturer Tecnam at least twice since 2025, with the latest warning issued just over a month before a training aircraft made by the firm crashed in Kanpur, killing two people, official communications revealed.

According to news agency PTI, the aviation regulator on July 10, 2026, told flying schools, which widely use the planes for pilot training, to follow safety regula-

tions issued by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AIB) following the May 12, 2022 crash of a twin-engine Tecnam P2006T in Haryana, which injured the crew. "Avoid parking Tecnam aircraft on apron/tarmac for prolonged periods during the summer season prior to commencing training flights," the regulator advised flying training organisations (FTOs).

On August 27, a trainee pilot and an instructor were killed when a Tecnam P2006T training aircraft crashed in Kanpur. →96

DELHI CAN REVISE JULY '29 MATURITY DATE FOR WOMEN'S AID RD, DOCS SHOW

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has kept the maturity period of recurring deposits (RDs) under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana open to revision, allowing the council of ministers to change the current deadline of July 31, 2028, following a review after two years, according to official documents. This gives the government flexibility to revisit the plan before the scheme's initial three-year tenure ends, with the review due in mid-2028.

The scheme's current tenure ends in July 2029, months after the next Lok Sabha elections.

2-DAY-OLD BABY AMONG 3 KILLED IN RAJ ACCIDENT

BIKANER: Three relatives, including a two-day-old baby, were killed in a road accident in Bikaner district of Rajasthan when they were returning home after the infant and her mother were discharged from a hospital, officials said on Sunday. The family was travelling in a Swift car, which collided with a Scorpio SUV from behind. →96

OPPN LEADERS TARGET BHAGWAT OVER U.S. EVENT

NEW DELHI: Opposition leaders from across parties on Sunday criticised Rashtriya Swamisevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat over his remarks in the US on India's "unity in diversity", accusing him of preaching tolerance abroad while remaining silent on alleged communal politics at home. →97

BIHAR-J'KHAND PACT ON SHARING RIVER SONE WATERS TODAY

Pallavi Singhal

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NEW DELHI: Bihar and Jharkhand will sign the agreement formalising the sharing of Sone river waters on Monday. This will close the dispute that has remained unresolved since Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar in 2000. →96

Nasa's new eye in the sky



Nasa launched its new flagship space telescope on Sunday, embarking on a multi-year mission to create an unprecedented map of the cosmos and shed light on some of the biggest mysteries in physics.

Related story on page 2

REUTERS

Army Cheetal carries out daring mission at 18,600ft in Ladakh

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NEW DELHI: Two Indian Army pilots pushed their single-engine Cheetal helicopter to its limits to evacuate an injured mountaineer near the Nun-Kun peaks in Ladakh's Zaskar range, landing at 18,600 feet with just one skid barely touching the treacherous snow-clad slope, officials aware of the matter said on Sunday. The pilots braved extreme weather and unforgiving terrain to evacuate the injured junior commissioned officer on Saturday but despite their efforts, the soldier died of his injuries. →95



Army personnel evacuate an injured soldier from a treacherous slope in the Zaskar range of Ladakh. INDIAN ARMY

NUMBER THEORY

PART 3

Rethinking Viksit Bharat: China, G7 and the contest for the world

By Sreedev Krishnakumar

The first and second parts of this series discussed India's manufacturing predicament in detail. No large country in the world has ever managed sustained high growth without exports. India cannot be an exception if it has to achieve high-income country status. Meanwhile, the world has changed from the days when exporting to advanced countries was the path to wealth.



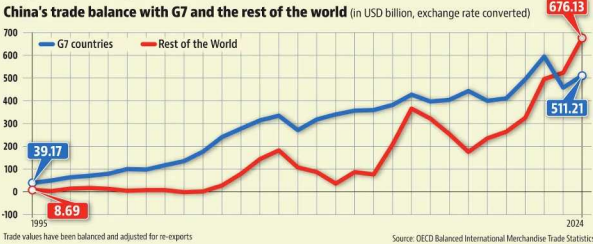
READ: Scan the QR code to read all parts in this series



1 China now runs a bigger trade surplus with the rest of the world than with the G7

For much of the past three decades, China's trade surplus looked primarily like a rich-world problem. The G7—Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the UK and the US—bought far more from China than it sold there. China ran a \$314 billion surplus with the G7 in 2007, more than twice its \$144 billion surplus with everyone else, according to data from OECD's Balanced

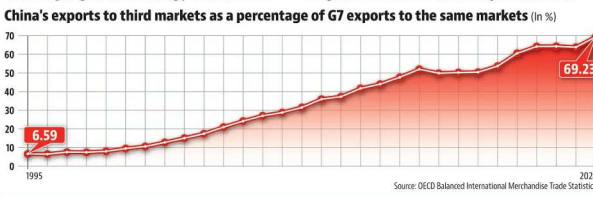
International Merchandise Trade Statistics (BIMTS), which balances reported bilateral trade values and adjusts them for re-exports. That is now changing. As of 2024, China's surplus with the G7 stands at \$511 billion, while its surplus with the rest of the world ballooned to \$676 billion. The latter overtook the former for the first time in 2023.



2 The real contest is now in third-country markets

In 1995, for every \$100 worth of goods the G7 exported to countries outside China and the G7 itself, China exported barely \$7. However, as of 2024, this is as much as \$69 for every \$100 exported by the G7 to the same third-country markets. A recent study published by the Kiel Institute for the World Economy, finds that China's export gains are increasingly concentrated in

machinery, vehicles, chemicals and other complex manufactures long dominated by advanced economies. "China's move toward more complex products, together with its export growth in these categories, has strongly affected advanced economies since a major competitor has emerged that is growing precisely in the product categories in which these countries specialise," it said.



3 To be sure, G7 is still increasing its exports, China is just doing it faster

To see what has changed, it helps to split the years since 1995 into four phases. The years 1995-2000 give us a pre-WTO baseline—China was already gaining ground, with its exports to third markets growing at a rate of 10% annually, compared with 2.3% for the G7. China's accession to the World Trade Organization in 2001 then ushered in what the US Federal Reserve in a recently published note called the first "China shock". The next period, 2007-18, captures the much slower global financial crisis and post-crisis era of global trade. Finally, 2018-24 covers what the US Fed calls "China Shock 2.0," a renewed export push from a country that was already the world's dominant goods exporter. China's entry into the WTO in 2001 accelerated reforms, investment and its

integration into world trade, helping explain the extraordinary 27.3% annual growth rate in its exports to non-G7 markets between 2000 and 2007. To be sure, G7 exports to China also grew 19.6% annually over the same period. China was becoming a formidable competitor, but also a rapidly growing customer. The financial crisis ended the boom years for global trade. China slowed too, but between 2007 and 2018 its non-G7 exports still grew 7.4% annually against 1.5% for the G7. Since 2018, the relationship has become more lopsided. China's exports to the G7 recorded an annual growth rate of just 1.1% and G7 exports to China shrank marginally, while Chinese exports to non-G7 markets grew at a rate of 7.58%, much faster than G7's exports to this group.

Annual growth in exports from China and G7 countries, by destination

Compound annual growth rate (%)

	China exports to G7	China exports to RoW	G7 exports to China	G7 exports to RoW
1995-2000	12.97	9.98	6.18	2.28
2000-2007	18.56	27.34	19.56	9.64
2007-2018	4.48	7.4	5.81	1.48
2018-2024	1.13	7.58	-0.08	2.03

Source: OECD Balanced International Merchandise Trade Statistics

China's rise used to be easiest to spot on Western shop shelves. The more uncomfortable part for the West now is what is happening elsewhere. China is increasingly selling to the same customers they depend on, while buying less from them in return. The second China shock is therefore as much a fight for export markets as an argument over imports. For India, that creates an

opening, but hardly an easy one. The real prize is not merely replacing China in Western supply chains, but becoming more competitive in the same third markets where China is already deeply entrenched, which will require much deeper trade integration and global value-chain participation. This cannot happen without a new deal for manufacturing in India.



Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

India, Uzbekistan boost ties, plan uranium pact

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NEW DELHI: India and Uzbekistan on Sunday raised their ties to a comprehensive strategic partnership, set a target of \$5 billion in annual trade by 2030 and agreed to work for the long-term supply of uranium during talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Shavkat Mirziyoyev in Tashkent.

Uzbekistan was the first stop in Modi's two-nation tour. Late on Sunday he arrived in Kyrgyzstan to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit. This was Modi's fourth visit to Uzbekistan, which he described as being at the heart of India's engagement with Central Asia.

The talks between the two leaders focused on enhancing cooperation in trade and investment, defence and security, infrastructure, critical minerals, innovation, AI, pharmaceuticals, digital public infrastructure including India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI), agriculture and education.

"India and Uzbekistan share a deep convergence of perspectives and aspirations," Modi told a joint media interaction, speaking in Hindi. "A stronger India-Uzbekistan partnership will be a powerful force for peace, progress and prosperity in Central Asia."

He noted that the two sides were elevating their ties to a comprehensive strategic partnership on the 15th anniversary of their strategic partnership. "Our bilateral trade has



Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev (right) confers Prime Minister Narendra Modi with the Oliy Darajali Do'stlik Order, the country's highest honour for foreign leaders. **PB**

crossed \$1 billion. We have now set a target of \$5 billion in bilateral trade by 2030. To achieve this, we will systematically address issues related to market access, connectivity, banking and payment systems," Modi said.

At the start of his talks with Mirziyoyev, Modi outlined several steps the two sides planned to take to deepen their relationship. "We will also establish a long-term arrangement for the supply of uranium," he said.

Sibi George, secretary (West) in the external affairs ministry, told reporters later that the two sides had "positive discussions" on a long-term arrangement for

continued on 97

MODI ARRIVES IN KYRGYZSTAN, TO TAKE PART IN SCO SUMMIT
Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday arrived in Kyrgyzstan, where he is scheduled to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit and hold a series of bilateral meetings on the sidelines, including with Russian president Vladimir Putin.

The PM was received at the airport by Kasmaliev Adyibek Aleshevich, chairman of the cabinet of ministers. "The SCO Summit brings together ten Member States, fifteen Partner countries and two observer countries to advance dialogue and cooperation on regional and global issues," Modi said. **PTI**

B'DESH, CHINA EYE TEESTA PROJECT, PLAN DEFENCE DIALOGUE
Bangladesh and China on Sunday signalled their intention to cooperate on a project to manage the Teesta river and to launch a new strategic dialogue between their foreign ministers as well as a diplomacy and defence dialogue.

The moves are unlikely to go down well in New Delhi, especially at a time when Dhaka is yet to respond to the Indian side's invitations to PM Tarique Rahman for a bilateral visit and participation in the upcoming Brics Summit. The Teesta is the only one of 54 trans-boundary rivers for which India and Bangladesh are yet to conclude a water-sharing pact. **AP9**

DRAFT DELHI S.I.R. ROLLS OUT TODAY, 34% VOTERS MAY RECEIVE NOTICES

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NEW DELHI: Nearly 34% of the Delhi electors whose names are published in the draft voter roll, but whose enumeration forms contain anomalies, are likely to face scrutiny and may receive notices during the next phase of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. Nearly 4.75 million electors are set to be left out of the draft roll to be published on Monday, officials said.

FIR AGAINST RAHUL OVER 'PURIFICATION RITUAL' REMARKS

HALDWANI/DEHRADUN: An FIR was registered on Sunday evening against Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi in Haldwani Kotwali police station in Uttarakhand's Nainital district over his alleged remarks concerning a "purification ritual" conducted at the local Ramilla Ground. **AP6**

IIT-D STIR PAUSED 'TILL PROBE PANEL REPORT IS OUT'

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NEW DELHI: Students at IIT-Delhi said on Sunday they have paused their protest over the alleged suicide of a 31-year-old student until the external inquiry committee's report is released, according to a press statement issued by a students' body.

NEET leak probe widens as ED seeks CBI case files

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NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has formally sought the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) complete case records in the alleged NEET-UG 2026 paper leak, as the financial crimes agency examines the alleged financial trail behind the examination scandal, people familiar with the development said on Sunday.

The ED has sought the CBI's charge sheet, witness statements, relied-upon documents and other case material through official channels. The request marks the first time the financial crimes investigation agency has formally sought information from the CBI in connection with the case.

ED HAS SOUGHT CBI'S CHARGE SHEET, WITNESS STATEMENTS, AND OTHER CASE MATERIAL VIA OFFICIAL CHANNELS

The move could add a new dimension to the investigation. While the CBI has investigated the alleged conspiracy behind the leak—from the setting of the question papers to the beneficiary candidates—the ED is examining the alleged financial aspects of the case and transactions connected with the alleged irregularities.

The ED has not yet registered a case under the Prevention of

continued on 97

266K CANDIDATES SIT FOR NEET PG, RETEST TO BE HELD FOR 2.4K

A total of 265,980 candidates appeared for the NEET-PG exam across 339 cities on Sunday, with authorities announcing a retest for 2,445 students who took the exam at two centres in Jaipur after repeated power failures disrupted the process. "NEET-PG 2026 successfully conducted nationwide with robust security and Real-Time Monitoring," the ministry of health said on X. The exam was scheduled from 9am to 12.30pm. However, according to affected candidates, the test could resume only around 10am after the initial power disruption, while several computer systems continued to malfunction. The ministry said that the retests for these students will be held on September 5. **AP7**

3-yr-old tied, beaten in Delhi playschool, 1 held

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NEW DELHI: A three-year-old boy was allegedly tied to a chair for hours and also subjected to severe physical abuse over several days at a playschool in northeast Delhi's Mayapuri that has international branches, police said on Sunday. An attendant has been arrested while a teacher, the school principal and director have been booked in connection with the case.

The incident first came to light earlier this month after the child's parents noticed behavioural changes as well as bruises on his body. They took him to the doctor who said the 3-year-old appeared

AN ATTENDANT WAS ARRESTED WHILE A TEACHER, THE SCHOOL PRINCIPAL, AND DIRECTOR HAVE BEEN BOOKED

to show signs of physical assault, including swelling in both ear canals. They then approached the school for CCTV footage from the classroom which revealed the abuse. His parents have also alleged he may have been sexually harassed and had become averse to being touched.

JUSTICE BHUYAN: 76 YEARS ON, WHY IS NO 'DISTINGUISHED JURIST' IN TOP COURT?

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NEW DELHI: Supreme Court Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday questioned why the constitutional provision allowing appointment of a "distinguished jurist" as a top court judge has remained unused for more than 76 years, suggesting that the Centre and, later, the collegium had either failed to find sufficient depth in Indian legal academia or had simply never seriously explored the possibility. He rejected as "very shallow" the argument that legal academics lack the practical experience necessary to become judges. **AP5**

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{ WORLD } AFTER REFERENDUM

Icelanders vote to remain out of EU



Icelanders voted to stay out of the European Union, referendum results showed on Sunday, as they rejected a government push to reopen membership talks and sided with those who said Iceland's fishing waters were too important to risk. The Arctic island of 400,000 people has debated whether to join the EU for well over a decade and had initially been expected to narrowly back membership talks, but opinion polls this month showed views had changed. Prime Minister Kristinn Fordóttir told a press conference that Iceland would focus on strengthening its existing ties with the European Union through the European Economic Area agreement, which it shares with Norway and Liechtenstein.

REUTERS

{ MY INDIA } SPEEDING CAR

Woman on phone runs over 8-yr-old in Bandra



An eight-year-old boy was on Sunday run over and killed by a speeding car, allegedly driven by a 45-year-old woman who was speaking on the mobile phone in Bandra area of Mumbai, police said, adding that she was arrested. The incident occurred opposite Jijamata Garden on John Baptist Road in the afternoon when Ansh Ravindra Gupta was crossing the road. A woman, identified as Megha Rawal, drove her Innova Crysta recklessly at an excessive speed, and while distracted on a phone call, forcefully knocked Gupta down and ran the vehicle over him, a police official said. The boy was rushed to a hospital but died of injuries.

PTI

{ WORLD } 270 ON BOARD

8 killed, 22 missing after ferry capsizes off Cyprus



At least eight people have died after a ferry carrying nearly 270 passengers and crew capsized off the coast of the breakaway north of ethnically divided Cyprus on Sunday, Turkish media reported. Unal Ustel, the north's Turkish Cypriot prime minister, told Turkish state broadcaster TRT that 237 people have so far been rescued. A search is underway for another 22 people, officials said. Ustel said the ferry faced adverse weather conditions and began taking on water just 15 minutes after departure. A call for help was issued shortly after, he said. Police detained eight people — including the ferry captain — as part of an investigation into the sinking, according to Ustel. Turkish Cypriot leader Tufan Erherman urged against speculating about the cause of the accident.

AP

{ BUSINESS } 'DESPITE HURDLES'

FM: India set to keep growth momentum



The Indian economy has been growing at 7% or more after the Covid pandemic and it is expected to maintain the growth momentum despite global uncertainties, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said while addressing the Indian diaspora in Chicago. "Uncertainties, which are before every economy, are only multiplying. We thought, we saw the worst when we went through Covid," she said, adding that India actually "recovered well" and since then it is sustaining the growth at 7% or more. "This year too, our growth will be at that range," she said, pointing at global uncertainties caused by two wars, tariff issues and the situation at Hormuz.

APRO

{ WORLD } MANHUNT ON

1 killed in shooting at Switzerland rave



A shooting at a rave in the northern Swiss canton of Aargau left one person dead and five injured early Sunday, local police and media reported. Police said they are still looking for potentially more than one suspect. Aargau cantonal police wrote earlier on X that a 22-year-old woman died at the scene. Four men and one woman were taken to the hospital with injuries ranging from minor to severe. All of the victims are residents of Switzerland, police said. They did not release their names in line with Swiss privacy rules. However, Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni identified the woman who was killed and two other victims as Italian citizens on Sunday evening. Aargau police said all its forces were involved in finding the suspect or suspects.

AP

Nasa's 'Roman' space telescope sets off to draw map of cosmos

Reuters

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CAPE CANAVERAL, FLORIDA: NASA's new flagship astronomical observatory was launched into space from Florida on Sunday on a mission to probe some of the biggest mysteries in astrophysics and cosmology.

The Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, a nearly \$4-billion project, was carried aloft from NASA's Kennedy Space Center aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket, embarking on a potentially decade-long observation mission.

The telescope, which will park itself beyond the moon, is designed to investigate cosmic enigmas such as dark energy and dark matter, while also testing gravity at vast scales and searching for exoplanets, as planets beyond our solar system are called.

Roman will travel through space toward an orbital location called Lagrange Point 2, situated about 1.6 million km from Earth. Its mission is planned for five years, though the space agency said the telescope may have enough fuel for five more years.

Mission specialists will spend the next 90 days commissioning the spacecraft and preparing the observatory for its science operations. It is expected to beam back its first high-resolution images "before the winter holidays."

Roman telescope project manager Jackie Townsend told reporters, Roman will build on the capabilities of other orbiting observatories such as the James Webb Space Telescope, launched in 2021, and the Hubble Space Telescope, launched in 1990.

"It will be as if Hubble and

ROMAN WILL ADD TO THE WORK OF OTHER ORBITING OBSERVATORIES LIKE THE JAMES WEBB AND HUBBLE SPACE TELESCOPES

James Webb kind of peered through a keyhole at the universe, while Nancy Grace Roman will kick the door down," said Nicola Fox, chief of NASA's Science Mission Directorate.

"Roman has broadly the same sensitivity and sharpness of vision as Hubble, but we survey the sky much faster," Julie McNerny, Roman's senior project scientist at NASA's Goddard Space Flight Center in Maryland, said in July.

McNerny said one month of Roman observations can survey our entire home galaxy. "One month of observations to survey the Milky Way would take about a century with Hubble," McNerny said.

Webb provided a new understanding of the early history of the universe, finding among other things that primordial galaxies formed sooner and were bigger than previously known. It is capable of looking across vast distances and back into deep time, because of the time it takes light to travel.

Roman instead is able to take panoramic views of the universe, Roman to a camera's wide-angle lens and Webb to a zoom lens.

Roman will help in the understanding of dark energy and dark matter by creating the most comprehensive 3D map of the universe to date.

IRAN WAR: 6 MONTHS ON, NO OFF-RAMP

The US and Israel launched strikes on Iran on February 28. The conflict has now turned into a costly stalemate as global economic faultlines widen and there is still no clear path to ending the war

TRACKING THE CONFLICT

FEBRUARY 28

US-Israeli strikes killed Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran struck 14 US military positions across West Asia and blocked the Strait of Hormuz.

MARCH 1 Three Indians were killed when Iran struck two tankers in the Gulf. Iran struck hotels and high-rises in Gulf cities.

MARCH 4 Iranian Navy ship IRIS Dena sunk by a US torpedo off the coast of Sri Lanka.

MARCH 8 Iran named Mojtaba Khamenei as the new Supreme Leader.

MARCH 27 An Iranian strike injured 12 US troops in Saudi Arabia at the Prince Sultan Air Base. An Indian naval vessel was hit by a missile.

APRIL 7 The US announced a two-week ceasefire after Trump threatened that Iran would strike a deal.

APRIL 11 Iran and Israel held talks in Pakistan, which failed and the US began a naval blockade of Iran.

MAY 6 US Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced the Operation Epic Fury was over.

JUNE 10 The US attacked Iran and struck a days-long funeral for Ali Khamenei.

JULY 25 Iran reports no US military strikes against Iran for the first time after 13 consecutive nights of strikes.

JULY 26 Two US service members were killed in Jordan while defending against Iranian strikes.

JULY 7 US struck dozens of targets in Iran and resumed sanctions after Iran allegedly struck ships.

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5 CONSEQUENCES OF THE WAR

1 Trump is paying a political price

With approval dropping to 33% and gas prices rising, the unpopular war threatens Republicans ahead of midterm elections and deepens party rifts.

2 The war has shaken the global economy — but less than feared

Strait of Hormuz disruptions spiked energy costs and trimmed global growth forecasts to 3%, though AI investment and reduced energy dependence softened the blow.

3 Shift to asymmetric deterrence by Iran

Despite losing key air defenses and naval vessels, Tehran retains drone and missile capabilities to control over the Strait of Hormuz, and a tightened grip on domestic dissent.

4 West Asia has been destabilised, exposing US allies

Retailer strikes on Gulf states and shipping routes have raised regional transport costs, disrupted trade, and left traditional US allies vulnerable.

5 US military readiness has been diminished

Eighteen US service-members have been killed and 750 injured. Vast stocks of US weapons have been consumed and military infrastructure has been badly damaged.

Warning labels on food packets and a regulatory pivot

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NEW DELHI: A red hexagon carrying words such as "HIGH FAT", "HIGH SUGAR" or "HIGH SALT" could soon become a familiar sight on packaged food in India. The FSSAI has proposed putting such warnings prominently on the front of packs, almost a fortnight after the Supreme Court questioned its reluctance to introduce a front-of-pack warning system and gave the regulator two weeks to take a final decision.

The significance of the proposal is not merely in the shape or colour of a new label, but in the shift in the regulatory approach that has followed the Supreme Court's intervention. For years, India's debate over front-of-pack labelling has centred on how nutrition information should be presented to consumers, with the FSSAI considering a star-rating system and extensive stakeholder consultations.

However, the court's intervention has now brought the focus squarely on a more direct question: should consumers be warned, at the point of purchase, when a packaged food is high in nutrients that can pose health risks?

The answer emerging from the regulator's latest advice is a proposed warning-based system, albeit one that will be introduced in phases and still has to go through the regulatory process, Supreme Court's subsequent directives.

What exactly is FSSAI proposing?

The regulator has proposed a red hexagonal warning on the front of packaged food where the product is high in any two or more of three specified nutrients — added fat, added sugar and salt, based on thresholds under the Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024, issued by the National Institute of Nutrition (ICMR-NIN). The label would spell out "HIGH FAT", "HIGH SUGAR" and/or "HIGH SALT". Specified sweetened beverages would carry a separate "HIGHLY SWEETENED BEVERAGE" warning.

The warnings are intended to be difficult to miss. FSSAI has proposed that they be displayed in a font one point larger than that used in the nutrition information table on the back of the pack. The affidavit also sets out illustrations showing combinations such as "HIGH FAT HIGH SUGAR", "HIGH SALT HIGH SUGAR" and "HIGH FAT HIGH SUGAR".

The system would initially be narrower than a blanket warning for every product high in one of these nutrients. Phase I would cover products high in two or more of the specified nutrients, along with specified sweetened beverages. Phase II would extend the warning to products high in any one of the nutrients.

The phased approach is intended to give consumers time to adapt to the industry time for reformulation.

There would also be exemptions. FSSAI has proposed excluding single-ingredient foods and products (including fresh produce, grains and cereals and pantry staples) inherently rich in fat, sugar or salt, such as ghee, edible oil, salt, sugar, jaggery and honey, subject to other applicable labelling requirements.

In practical terms, therefore, the proposal could change what consumers see before they turn a packet around to read its nutrition table. Instead of requiring a shopper to interpret grams of sugar, sodium and sodium buried in the nutritional information, the front of the packet would provide an immediate warning where the product crosses the prescribed thresholds.

Why did the Supreme Court push FSSAI to act?

The proposal follows an unusually direct intervention by the Supreme Court in a PIL filed by 3S and Our Health Society. On August 13, a bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran took exception to the regulator's reluctance to introduce front-of-pack warnings despite the court having earlier asked it to consider the measure.

The court described front-of-pack labelling (FoPL) as an "assistive device" to help consumers make informed purchasing decisions and healthier dietary choices, saying its purpose was to put readily understood nutrition information on the package at the moment a purchasing decision is made.

The bench's concern was particularly focussed on children. It noted that obesity had emerged as a public-health challenge and referred to data showing that the proportion of overweight school-age children and adolescents had risen from 2% in 2000 to 10% in 2022. It also cited a contrast in children's food environments: while around 80% of food and beverages available to school children were freshly cooked meals, nearly 80% of what was available around schools consisted of packaged snacks.

The court also referred to the Economic Survey 2025-26, which recorded that India's ultra-processed food market had increased by more than 150% between 2009 and 2023, during a period when obesity had dou-

The warning signs

WHAT THE LABELS MAY LOOK LIKE

Red hexagonal warning on the front of packaged food where the product is high in any two or more of three specified nutrients — added fat, added sugar and salt, based on thresholds according to the Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024.

The affidavit also sets out illustrations showing combinations such as "HIGH FAT HIGH SALT", "HIGH SALT HIGH SUGAR" and "HIGH FAT HIGH SUGAR".

(*To be separately carried by specified sweetened beverages)

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TWO-STAGE ROLLOUT

Phase I: To cover products high in two or more of the specified nutrients, along with specified sweetened beverages.

Phase II: To extend the warning to products high in any one of the nutrients.

THE EXEMPTIONS

FSSAI has proposed leaving out single-ingredient foods and products inherently rich in fat, sugar or salt, such as ghee, edible oil, salt, sugar, jaggery and honey.

The court ultimately gave the Union and FSSAI two weeks to place their final decision on record, while warning that it could issue further directions if they did not act.

How does the proposed system compare with other countries?

The Supreme Court's August 13 order itself pointed to the experience of Chile, Israel and Canada, while noting that front-of-pack labelling is globally prevalent.

The affidavit reproduces the Chilean experience in particular. Chile introduced its warning-label system in phases. In the first phase in 2016, a product was labelled "high sugar content" if it contained more than 22.5 grams of sugar per 100 grams. In the third phase in 2019, that threshold had been lowered to 10 grams per 100 grams. The affidavit says the change resulted in a substantial reduction in consumer appetite, across socioeconomic groups, for products high in salt, sugar, saturated fat and calories.

Canada introduced a similar system in 2022, using front-of-pack nutrition symbols. According to the court order, the Canadian initiative was aimed not only at helping consumers make informed dietary choices but also at encouraging manufacturers to reformulate products for better health. The Canadian system also provided for different categorisation and exemptions.

The broader international picture is that there is no single global FoPL design. WHO identifies front-of-pack labelling as a

policy tool to make nutrition information easier to interpret and help consumers make healthier choices; it lists schemes adopted or being evaluated in countries including Australia, Belgium, Chile, France, Israel, Italy, Mexico, Norway, Spain, Sweden and the UK. WHO does not prescribe one particular system.

India's proposed approach is therefore closer to interpretive warning labels than to a star-rating system. That distinction matters, since the consumer is not being asked to calculate whether a product is healthy or unhealthy from a score. The label is designed to provide a direct warning when specified nutrient thresholds are crossed.

What could change for consumers and the food industry?

If implemented, the biggest change could be where and how consumers encounter nutrition information. The current detailed nutritional information is designed to be read and interpreted by the consumer reads the back-of-pack label.

For consumers, the stated objective is greater clarity. The Supreme Court said the value of FoPL lies not merely in disclosure but in clarity, with the difference between being told something and being informed about it.

For manufacturers, the implications could extend beyond packaging. The FSSAI's phased

approach expressly recognises the need to give industry time for reformulation, meaning products could be altered to reduce the quantities of nutrients that trigger warnings. The international experience cited by the court suggests that warning systems can operate not only as consumer-information tools but also as an incentive for manufacturers to change product composition.

At the same time, the FSSAI proposal is intended to reduce the regulatory process. The regulator has said the changes will be brought through amendments to the relevant regulations after the prescribed procedure is followed.

The Supreme Court has, meanwhile, made clear that it sees the issue as more than a question of packaging design. It linked the right to health with Article 21, saying the constitutional guarantee of life carries a corresponding duty on the State not only to refrain from actions that impair health but also to take affirmative steps to protect it. It also referred to Article 47, which casts a duty on the State to promote public health as a primary obligation.

Therefore, the red hexagon is not merely a new label. If the FSSAI proposal passes the Supreme Court's muster and the regulatory process, it would mark a shift in India's food policy from requiring consumers to decode nutrition information to putting a clear warning in front of them, amid the top court's emphatic enunciation that public health, particularly the health of children, cannot be an afterthought.

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MY BENGALURU

20 arrests IAS officer in KPSC exam process

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) on Sunday arrested IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar in connection with alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) examination for 400 veterinary officer posts, officials familiar with the matter said.

Gangwar, a 2016 batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer who is currently Director of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, was the KPSC examination controller from February 2024 to March 2026. He was taken into custody late Saturday after several hours of questioning. Officials said investigators found inconsistencies in his statements and felt he was uncooperative.

"We took him into custody on Saturday and the arrest was formalised on Sunday evening," said an officer familiar with the development.

According to officials, Gangwar was questioned for about



Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar

nine hours in Bengaluru on Friday before the interrogation continued on Saturday. Investigators are examining his role in the examination's conduct, including the handling of question papers, evaluation and alleged manipulation of OMR answer sheets.

The FIR alleges that Gangwar received 41 crore from 2 candidates in return for tampering with their OMR sheets. He has been booked under Section 318 (3) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Section 10 of the Karnataka Public Examination (Measures for Prevention of Corruption & Unfair Means in

Recruitment) Act.

The state government transferred the case to the CID on July 28 after two cases were registered at Vidhana Soudha police station. The complaint was filed by veterinarian Manjunath against suspended former KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukara and others. Manjunath alleged that relatives of the former chairman, KPSC members and staff obtained unusually high marks in the examination conducted on January 8 and 9 despite having average academic records. He also alleged that some candidates who had cleared national-level competitive examinations performed poorly in the state recruitment test.

The complaint raised further questions about the candidates' conduct before the examination. Some candidates alleged that shortlisted aspirants switched off their mobile phones before or on the examination days and stayed at hotels and resorts outside Karnataka, where intermediaries allegedly provided them with the ques-

tions.

Manjunath also questioned the authenticity of OMR answer sheets. He alleged that candidates who had left several questions unanswered nevertheless secured high marks, while intermediaries offered to manipulate OMR sheets for up to 280 rupees.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is separately examining the alleged irregularities in the exam. On August 23, the agency searched Gangwar's residence in Jayamahal Extension, Bengaluru. Officials familiar with the details said Gangwar was in Uttar Pradesh when the search took place and that candidates allegedly entered the residence using a duplicate key.

Gangwar had also come under scrutiny earlier this month after he remained out of contact for two days starting August 20. He later contacted the government and said he had gone to his hometown on a family emergency. State home minister Priyank Kharge subsequently said that no IAS officer had gone missing.

STATE BJP TO TAKE OUT 'PADAYATRA' TO RAISE MAIN ISSUES FROM SEPT 1 TO 10

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BENGALURU: Karnataka BJP President Vijayendra on Sunday said the party's padayatra to Ballari will begin on September 1 to September 10.

He added that several issues, including the recent resignation of Congress leader Nagendra, will be raised during the march.

"There is absolutely no confusion about our padayatra. Our padayatra will start on September 1 and will end on September 10. We have several issues that will be discussed during our padayatra, when Basavanna Bommai will be the chief minister, reservation for SC was increased from 15 per cent to 17 per cent, and for ST it was increased from 3 per cent to 7 per cent. But after Congress came to power, they have not implemented this," he said.

Gangwar said the padayatra would highlight issues concerning people across the state and would serve as a platform to raise concerns related to governance and development.

Ballari Rural MLA had stepped down on Friday amid opposition party's BJP's pressure over the alleged Karnataka Maharshi Vaimil Scheduled Tribe Development Corporation scam.

BJP accepts Nagendra's resignation as minister

HT Correspondent
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BENGALURU: Governor Thawarchand Gehlot on Sunday accepted B Nagendra's resignation from the state cabinet, ending his second stint as minister after 25 days as the BJP and JD(S) intensified their campaign over alleged irregularities involving funds of the Karnataka Maharshi Vaimil Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation. The resignation, submitted on Friday, was accepted with immediate effect on the recommendation of chief minister D K Shivakumar. The BJP and JD(S) had demanded his removal and stepped up protests over the alleged diversion of corporation funds.

Karnataka leader of Opposition B Ashoka described Nagendra's resignation as the result of sustained pressure from the BJP and JD(S), calling it a "victory for the Dait community".

"We fought continuously for eight days from the beginning of the session. We have taught Congress a lesson. There is no established guilt, for the first time, Ashoka said. He said the BJP and JD(S) had taken the issue to its 'logical conclusion' and claimed that the Opposition had released 31 documents relating to the case.

Shivakumar, speaking to



B Nagendra

reporters at Ravindra Kalakshetra on Saturday, said Nagendra resigned after being hurt by "false allegations" made by the Opposition and the disruption of Assembly proceedings.

The controversy dates to May 2024, when an accounts superintendent with the corporation died by suicide and left a six-page note alleging irregularities and unauthorised transfers of funds. Subsequent investigations found that 899.63 crore had been transferred from a corporation account to a Union Bank of India account and then moved through multiple other accounts. Nagendra was tribal welfare minister when the controversy surfaced and resigned from the Cabinet in June 2024. His return to the ministry on August 3 revived the Opposition's demand for his removal.

Congress state president B K Hariprasad defended Nagendra, saying his resignation did not establish his guilt. He said Nagendra had accepted moral responsibility while maintaining that guilt could be determined only by investigating agencies and courts.

"Nowhere is anyone saying that the allegations have been

proved. The fact that he has resigned does not mean that the allegations have been proved. By resigning, Nagendra has set a higher standard in his political life and has taken moral responsibility. Resignation is not a certificate proving guilt," Hariprasad said.

Hariprasad accused the BJP of targeting an ST leader and applying different standards to opposition leaders and BJP leaders facing criminal allegations. He also referred to a special court's bail order and claimed it recorded that there was no evidence showing Nagendra had received 894.73 crore.

"Nagendra was not even an accused in the SIT charge sheet," he said. "If there are documents, let them prove it in court. But we cannot accept a politics that portrays an allegation itself as punishment," Hariprasad said.

He said the Congress would continue to defend Nagendra while allowing the CBI, ED and other agencies to investigate the allegations. "If he is guilty, let the court punish him. But we will not allow the BJP office to sit and write the verdict," he said.

Nagendra had accused the BJP of using the controversy to mislead people and alleged that the Opposition had prevented discussion of issues including drought, the Cauvery dispute and alleged irregularities in the KPSC during the Assembly session. Public works department and Belagavi district in-charge minister Satish Jarkiholi said Congress was expected to induce another leader to replace him till the vacancy. He said the party would decide on a second vacant Cabinet berth reserved for a woman.

State forms sub committee to review pending criminal cases

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government has formed two cabinet sub committees, assigning one to examine criminal cases pending trial across the state and another to address problems faced by students and propose reforms in the education sector.

The six-member panel on criminal cases will be chaired by minister Priyank Kharge and will examine cases pending before courts before making recommendations on whether they should be withdrawn according to a government notification. K H Muniyappa, U T Khader, Krishna Byre Gowda, H C Balakrishna and Yathindra Siddarama are the other members of the panel. The notification said the committee would scrutinise the pending cases and submit its recommendations to the state government. The home department has been directed to assist the panel. "As per Rule 13(5) of the Karnataka government (Transparency of Business) Rules, 1977, the home department should provide the necessary assistance to this cabinet sub committee," the order said. The government

THE SIX-MEMBER PANEL ON CRIMINAL CASES WILL BE CHAIRED BY MINISTER PRIYANK KHARGE AND WILL EXAMINE CASES PENDING BEFORE COURTS

has separately appointed a five-member cabinet sub committee to examine issues affecting students and propose broad changes across the education system. Health and family welfare minister U T Khader will head the panel.

The committee was constituted following a Cabinet decision on August 2, according to a memorandum issued by the Karnataka government secretariat on Wednesday. Higher education minister Basavanna Rayareddy, home, IT and E Governance minister Priyank Kharge, medical education and skill development minister Sharan Prakash Padgaonkar and school education minister Madhu Bangarappa are its members.

The education panel has been tasked with examining six broad

areas, beginning with the conduct of examinations and recruitment. It will consider measures to prevent question paper leakage and establish a fixed, time bound calendar for examinations and recruitment. The committee will also examine the cost of education, including regulation of fees charged by private institutions and oversight of coaching centres. It will consider measures to reduce the financial burden on students and their families.

Public education infrastructure and health and family welfare minister U T Khader will head the panel. The panel will examine the condition of government schools, pre-university colleges and universities, along with teacher vacancies and the availability of laboratories, libraries, hostels and other essential facilities. It will also consider curriculum changes and the need for expanding education, skills and employment. Among the areas under review will be ways to align courses with emerging employment opportunities, while expanding skills training, internships between educational institutions and industry.

WOMAN'S BODY FOUND HIDDEN UNDER TRAIN SEAT IN DHARWAD

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BENGALURU: A woman's body was found hidden under a seat in the women's compartment of a train after it reached Dharwad from Solapur on Sunday, police said, adding that a murder case was registered.

The woman, believed to be between 30 and 35 years old, was discovered at about 11 a.m, roughly 30 minutes after the train arrived at Dharwad railway station. Railway staff found the body while entering the coach for cleaning. The train had reached Solapur from Maharashtra on Saturday night and reached Dharwad at around 9.30 a.m. Railway personnel alerted the police after finding the body and they began investigating.

Railway deputy superintendent of police Somnashree Juttal said injuries were visible on the woman's neck, face and chest, leading investigators to suspect that she had been killed during the journey. Police registered a murder case, although the woman's identity was not known. "We have registered a case of murder and are investigating all possible angles. There are no marks on her neck, face and chest," Juttal said.

There was initially suspicion that she may have been sexually assaulted before her death. Police, however, said they had found no evidence of rape. The authorities are awaiting the post-mortem findings for further clarity.

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BENGALURU: Karnataka began a month-long door-to-door re-verification of 14 million Gruha Lakshmi beneficiaries on Sunday, using biometric and facial authentication to identify those who remain eligible for the ₹20,000 monthly benefit.

The exercise follows government data showing that ₹17.31 crore was credited to the bank accounts of 1,05,562 beneficiaries after their deaths.

A total of 3,12,287 beneficiaries died between the launch of the scheme and the end of June 2026, according to the chief minister's office.

The payments made after their deaths are among the discrepancies the government is seeking to address through the exercise.

The government issued the order approving the exercise on August 28. It has been sanctioned within a ₹20 crore spending limit and is to be completed within a month under a standard operating procedure approved by chief minister D K Shivakumar.

"In view of the matters exposed in the proposal, administrative approval is hereby accorded for re-verification of beneficiaries registered under the Gruha Lakshmi Scheme using biometric and facial authentication to identify eligible beneficiaries," the government order said.

The department of women and child development will supervise the exercise, while the e-Governance department will provide technical and operational support.

A web and mobile application developed by the directorate of electronic delivery of citizens services will be used for the verification.

Officials will visit beneficiaries at their homes and distribute printed enumeration forms which must be completed and collected during the exercise. If a beneficiary is unavailable, another family member can fill out the form.

Household visits have been mandated mandatory even if the required information is available through other sources or verification systems, according to the standard operating procedure.

Enumerators will use a designated mobile application containing beneficiary lists arranged by village and urban area. A photograph will be captured against the beneficiary's name during each visit, while the application will automatically record the GPS coordinates of the residence.

Beneficiaries who are unavailable during the household visit and cannot complete facial authentication will be informed through multiple communication channels. They will then be

THE EXERCISE FOLLOWS DATA SHOWING THAT ₹17.31 CRORE WAS CREDITED TO THE BANK ACCOUNTS OF 1,05,562 BENEFICIARIES AFTER DEATHS

required to complete biometric authentication at their assigned Fair Price Shops or the nearest Karnataka One. Grama One or Bengaluru One centre.

The government will also use biometric authentication data already collected at Fair Price Shops.

The verification is intended to ensure that beneficiaries who are no longer eligible and ensure that payments reach those who qualify under the scheme. The government is also identifying other eligible members of families of deceased beneficiaries who can be considered as replacements.

Officials said so far distributed ₹76,951 crore under Gruha Lakshmi. Women heads of households receive ₹2,000 in each instalment directly into their bank accounts. The 32 instalments credited since the scheme was launched.

The recovery of money transferred to deceased beneficiaries is also a priority for the Karnataka Government. The highest number of deaths among beneficiaries, at 24,705, while Kodagu has recorded the lowest, with 2,291.

NIA court awards 7 yrs to man in ISIS-linked terror conspiracy case

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BENGALURU: An NIA court sentenced a man to seven years of rigorous imprisonment for his involvement in an ISIS-linked terror conspiracy aimed at carrying out targeted killings to provoke communal riots, an official statement issued on Sunday said.

According to the National Investigation Agency (NIA) investigation, the conspiracy was masterminded by Mehboob Pasha, the prime accused in the case, who conducted several meetings at his residence in Gurappanapalya, Bengaluru.

In these meetings, the accused planned targeted killings to incite communal riots and further the anti-national agenda of the proscribed ISIS terror organisation, the statement added.

Convicted accused Syed Fasiur Rehman alias Syed Faez U Rehman participated in these conspiracy meetings and purchased tents and knives from a Deception Store store for jungle-camp training of AI-Hind group members, the statement said.

The conspiracy aimed to establish an ISIS/Daesh wilayah (province), the anti-terror agency said. Rehman has been sentenced to seven years of rigorous imprisonment and fined ₹8,40,000.

The case was initially registered by the Karnataka State Police on January 10, 2020, in Bengaluru and was subse-

THE NIA SAID THE CONSPIRACY WAS MASTERMINDED BY MEHBOOB PASHA. THE KEY ACCUSED IN THE CASE, WHO CONDUCTED MANY MEETINGS AT HIS RESIDENCE IN GURAPPANAPALYA,

quently taken over and re-registered by the NIA on January 3 of that year.

As of now, the NIA has filed three chargesheets against 20 accused individuals. Previously, Haneef Khan was convicted on July 14, 2026, after pleading guilty during the trial, which began in October 2025.

As part of the ongoing investigation, the NIA is working to trace the online handler responsible for planning and coordinating the establishment of the module involved in the conspiracy, the statement said.

The NIA investigation identified Mehboob Pasha as the prime accused and alleged that he was the mastermind of the conspiracy. Several meetings were held at his residence in Bengaluru, where the accused allegedly discussed plans for targeted killings with the intention of provoking communal violence. The NIA said the investigation is continuing to trace the online handler who allegedly planned the conspiracy, which involved in the terror activity.

23-YR-OLD DEAD, PARTNER INJURED AFTER FALL FROM 7TH FLOOR: POLICE

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BENGALURU: A 23-year-old software engineer died after a fall from the seventh floor of a residential building in Whitefield on Sunday, while a 30-year-old man sustained critical injuries, according to police. The two both from Pudukchery, had reportedly been in a relationship for about six years.

The fall took place at about 11.50 a.m. Police said the preliminary inquiry was examining whether differences between the couple precluded the incident. The man was believed to have attempted to take her own life by jumping from the building, police said.

There appears to have been a rift between the couple, with one of the primary angles they are examining as a possible reason behind the incident. However, our investigation is still under way. The woman was around 23-years-old and had been working as a software engineer in Whitefield for the last eight months," Gowda said. Officers have also begun speaking to people familiar with the couple as they seek to establish the circumstances preceding the fall. A Unofficial Death Report has been filed by Whitefield police, and the investigation is on.

Forest dept introduces strict sops for trekking

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka Forest Department has introduced a comprehensive Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) to regulate eco-tour and trekking activities across the state's forest divisions and to safeguard trekkers while preserving ecological integrity.

According to a press release, Karnataka's Western Ghats and forest regions host nearly 39 designated trekking routes. However, recent incidents in 2026, including a fatal leopard attack in Male Mahadevashwara Hills, a missing trekker rescue operation at Tadiandamol in Kodagu, and a critical incident at Bandaje Waterfalls in Chikmagalur, have underscored the inherent risks of deep-forest navigation, extreme weather, limited cellular connectivity, and active wildlife movements.

In response, the newly formulated SOP establishes strict governance over forest access, mandating route safety assessments before reopening trails to the public.

Key measures outlined in the policy include entry limits on designated trails to prevent crowding and enable continuous monitoring of every group by forest staff.

It will also include engagement of local youth trained in biodiversity, navigation, head-count management, and emergency response to accompany trekking groups, deployment of GPS-enabled communication devices, and requiring trekkers from becoming untraceable in remote regions.

The provision of clear directional signs, marked paths, rest stops, and basic amenities (drinking water and toilets) at base camps and temporary suspension or restriction of routes upon detection of key wildlife, such as tigers, leopards, elephants, or bears, will also be a part of the policy, it added.

Along with the coordinated protocols, integrating Forest personnel, SDRF units, local communities, and drone monitoring for search and rescue operations will be included, the release said.

The Department emphasised that forest trails pass through sensitive natural habitats and cannot be treated as standard tourist roads.

BJP MP leads march against Lalbagh park and diversion

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BENGALURU: BJP MP Tejasvi Surya, along with citizens' organisations and Residents' Welfare Associations (RWAs), participated in a protest march against Lalbagh being given Sunday to protect the city's green spaces, amid opposition to a state government bill allowing diversion of park land for development.

More than 5,000 people have gathered today organically in Lalbagh to oppose the tunnel road project and to oppose the city's green spaces. Union minister Shobha Karandlaje also participated in the march and said the issue went beyond Lalbagh and concerned the future of Bengaluru and Karnataka. It is not just about saving Lalbagh; it is about saving our Bengaluru and saving Karnataka," Karandlaje said. She criticised the Karnataka Government Parks (Preservation) (Amendment) Bill, 2026, alleging that it was passed without adequate discussion.

"A draconian bill has been introduced in Karnataka—one that was passed without any dis-



Tejasvi Surya

cussion," she said.

Karandlaje alleged that the government was prioritising real estate over the preservation of green spaces.

"The current administration in the Karnataka Legislative Assembly is a real estate pawnsment; whenever they get an open land, they see only real estate. They see money," she said. "We met the Governor and wrote to him, but he returned the bill. The government is now considering not reintroducing it; otherwise, we are prepared to take the matter all the way to the President," Karandlaje added.

The union minister had recently written to Karnataka Governor Thawarchand Gehlot urging him to withdraw the bill. She said the bill would allow the state government to recommend the formation of a High-Level Committee, to allocate or permit the use of up to five per cent of the total area of a park or garden for specific purposes.

She had argued that the provision diluted the statutory protection allotted to public green spaces and could open the way for their diversion for construction and development.

TAMIL NADU GOVT
TRACES 219 OF 319
PILGRIMS STUCK IN
FLOOD-HIT NEPAL

On August 24, the state high court directed the government to ensure that construction of the proposed Gandhi A Hydroelectric

High-risk glacier lakes in India under scanner after massive floods in Nepal

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NEW DELHI: More than 200 glacier lakes in the Indian Himalayas have been flagged for either high-risk assessment or intensified monitoring in separate government assessments, bringing renewed focus to the country's mountain hazards after the devastating flash floods in Nepal.

The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) has identified 185 vulnerable glacier lakes across six Himalayan states and Union territories, including 67 classified as Category A, or "very high risk". Separately, the Central Water Commission (CWC), in its latest monitoring report for June 2026, flagged 147 glacier lakes that recorded an increase in water spread during the month and said they required vigorous monitoring. The vulnerable lakes identified by the NDMA include 48 in Himachal Pradesh, 41 in Sikkim, 34 in Ladakh, 32 in Uttarakhand Pradesh, 27 in Jammu and Kashmir and 13 in Uttarakhand.

The heightened scrutiny matters because a failure of a glacier lake can trigger destructive floods far downstream, often in difficult-to-access areas where warning and evacuation are challenging.

Krishna Vatsa, a member of the NDMA, said mitigation efforts focus primarily on reducing the volume of water in vulnerable lakes and the pressure on the moraine dams that contain them. The authority is also testing early warning systems that could eventually be deployed across vulnerable lakes. "We recently did some work in Himachal Pradesh, where EWS was tested at a lake, but at a lower height. We will now test this at much higher heights, particularly in Sikkim. Once tested, it can be replicated across all dangerous lakes," Vatsa said. The CWC's June 2026 assessment provides a broader picture of changes in the glacier-lake landscape. It currently monitors 2,843

149 INDIANS RESCUED FROM NEPAL: MEA

NEW DELHI: A total of 149 Indian have been rescued after the ongoing relief operations following the flash floods in Nepal, the ministry of external affairs said in an official update. This comes as the total number of Indians recovered following the devastating flash floods in Nepal has reached 794 as of 5:45 PM on Sunday, Nepal Police said.

glacier lakes and water bodies larger than 10 hectares across Indian Himalayan river basins. Of the 681 glacier lakes located within India in the National Remote Sensing Centre's Global Lake Atlas of Indian River Basins, the CWC found that 147 showed an increase in water spread during June 2026. These included 42 in Himachal Pradesh, 41 in Sikkim, 30 in Jammu and Kashmir, five in Himachal Pradesh and four in Uttarakhand. The threat is restricted to water accumulating behind potentially unstable moraine dams. A May 2026 study published in *npr Natural Hazards* highlighted that hanging glaciers, or ice masses perched on steep slopes that can break away and trigger avalanches or cascading hazards.

Anil Kulkarni, a visiting scientist at the Divyach Centre for Climate Change at IISc and one of the study's authors, said hanging glaciers remain poorly studied in India. "We realised hanging glaciers are not that well studied in the country and can pose an equally high risk. The assessment was done by a team of experts, including glaciologists, to help agencies carry out mitigation measures," he said. Simon Stiel, executive secretary of the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change, said that the Nepal floods were a reminder of the fragility of mountain environments. "A warming climate is making tragedies like this one much more frequent and severe, with vulnerable communities often hardest hit," he said.



Rescue work continues at Trishuli Center in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Sunday, after flooding on the Nepal-Tibet border.

'We had given up hope': Vidarbha man on return from Kathmandu

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NAGPUR: A group of 106 Vidarbha pilgrims who travelled to Kathmandu on August 19 for a religious retreat returned to Nagpur on Sunday after being stranded in Nepal following devastating flash floods.

While 102 pilgrims arrived at Nagpur railway station on Sunday, four others had not returned. The pilgrims had travelled to Kathmandu via the Pashupatinath temple. Their plans changed on August 26, when reports of flash floods in Nepal raised concerns about their safety and their return journey. Though the worst of the destruction was reported around 100 km away near the Nepal-Tibet border, the pilgrims said they were worried as heavy rain and



Pilgrims arrive at Nagpur railway station on Sunday.

flooded disrupted routes out of the country. "We did not sleep or eat properly. All we could think of was how we were going to escape and reach safely," said 68-year-old Sushila Mundre. Adharva Dusane, 24, who was travelling with his sister and other relatives, said the group at one point feared it would not be able to return home. "It was so dangerous that at one point, we had given up all hope of ever returning home," he

said, adding that they saw floodwaters and people being swept away. The group began its journey back to India in four buses, travelling towards the border through Bihar. During the journey, they witnessed the impact of the floods firsthand. "A bus carrying other tourists was swallowed by the surging waters right in front of our eyes," said 64-year-old Mangala Karsang.

The evacuation was facilitated by coordinated efforts involving the Maharashtra government. The chief minister's office said CM Devendra Fadnis remained in touch with Nepal PM Sundeep Rana over arrangements for the pilgrims' safe return. After reaching Sitamarhi, local authorities provided the pilgrims food and temporary shelter before they were moved to Patna. From there, two dedicated low-lying areas and damaged homes, roads and bridges

BODIES CONTINUE TO EMERGE IN U.P. RIVER CLOSER TO NEPAL BORDER

HT Correspondents
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GORAKHPUR/KANPUR: Three more bodies were recovered from the Narayani River in Kushinagar on Sunday, taking the combined toll of flash floods in the combined states of Uttar Pradesh and neighbouring Bihar to 17. The bodies are expected to have been swept downstream after flash floods in Nepal on August 26.

Kushinagar additional district magistrate Vaibhav Mishra said NDRF personnel recovered three bodies near Thokar Numbers 3 and 4 in Khadda tehsil. A fourth body was swept away by the strong current before it could be retrieved. The identities of those recovered were not immediately known. Kushinagar district disaster response officer Ravi Rai said 11 bodies had been recovered from the Narayani in the district, while six were recovered in Maharajganj near the India-Nepal border on August 27. Officials said the Gandak's water level has been rising unevenly, prompting the administration to keep SDRF, NDRF and other emergency teams on standby.

The Narayani, known as the Gandak in Bihar, has been receiving increased flows following the collapse of a glacier on Wednesday unleashed a torrent of ice, rock, mud and debris down Himalayan rivers. Authorities said 16 people had been killed on its side of the border, including one on Saturday evening and that 546 were missing.

In Nepal, the disaster authority said at least 675 people were killed on its side of the border, 2,498 are missing and 7,514 have been rescued. Local police told Reuters that rescuers and rescue workers have moved to higher ground after the water level in the nearby Trishuli River rose over



Officers transport bodies to the pit at Devghat mass burial site for flood victims in Chitwan, Nepal on Sunday.

49 Indians among 261 foreigners still missing on Tibetan side: China

Reuters
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BEIJING/TRISHULI: China on Sunday said 261 foreign nationals from 23 countries, including 49 Indians, were missing on the Tibetan side of a border crossing with Nepal following a mudslide which tore through the Himalayan region, while the death toll in Tibet has reached 16 people. Officials from China's Tibet Autonomous Region said at a press conference that the highest number of missing foreigners were from Nepal at 104, while 49 Indian, 33 Latvian, 18 American and 15 British citizens were also unaccounted for. They said authorities in Beijing have notified foreign missions.

The nationality breakdown was the first from the Chinese side since the collapse of a glacier on Wednesday unleashed a torrent of ice, rock, mud and debris down Himalayan rivers. Authorities said 16 people had been killed on its side of the border, including one on Saturday evening and that 546 were missing. In Nepal, the disaster authority said at least 675 people were killed on its side of the border, 2,498 are missing and 7,514 have been rescued. Local police told Reuters that rescuers and rescue workers have moved to higher ground after the water level in the nearby Trishuli River rose over

NEPAL: MASS BURIAL OF UNIDENTIFIED VICTIMS

CHITWAN: Nepal's scenic Chitwan district, known for its forests and rivers, has become the site of mass burials for hundreds of unidentified victims whose bodies were swept away by the torrent that devastated the Himalayan region days ago. In the plains, nearly 200 kilometers from the flood-ravaged valleys of Rasuwa where the disaster struck on Wednesday, authorities have dug hundreds of graves in the open, saying it is a "new and grim sight". "We were left with no other option and had to take this step. Our concern was the risk to public health posed by the rapid decomposition of the bodies," said Ganesh Aryal, chief district officer of Baripur, Chitwan.

Authorities buried 26 unidentified bodies in the forest on Saturday and planned to bury more than 100 others on Sunday, as recovery teams continue to retrieve victims from rivers and piles of debris. The disaster, caused by glacier instability under the long-term effects of global warming, Chinese state broadcaster CCTV reported on Sunday, saying it is a "new and prominent feature of cryosphere disasters" on the Tibetan plateau.

40, including Asian Games medalist, join BJP in Punjab

CHANDIGARH: Asian Games gold medalist Manpreet Kaur, former leader Nirmal Singh and former members of AAP, Congress and SAD were among around 40 people to join the BJP in Chandigarh on Sunday. Haryana chief minister Nayab Singh Saini welcomed them into the party fold and said people of Punjab have become disillusioned with the AAP government.

Abhishek gets police notice over fight at office

KOLKATA: Kolkata police have served a notice on TMC leader Abhishek Chatterjee in connection with a scuffle between officials and private guards of his office over removing a billboard bearing party signage earlier this week, an officer said on Sunday.

Assam to get govt proton beam therapy unit: CM

GUWAHATI: Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday said the northeastern state is set to become the third state in the country to have a proton beam therapy Centre for cancer treatment and the first in the government sector, entailing an investment of ₹600 crore.

Salaries to be cut for maintenance default: Odisha CM

BHUBANESWAR: Odisha chief minister Mohan Charan Mahanta on Sunday announced that the government will directly deduct court-ordered payments from the monthly salaries of state employees who default on maintenance and fail to pay it monthly to their wives or children.

[GREENPIECE]

Nepal flood should be wake-up call for India

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NEW DELHI: Do you recall the horrific event at Randa, Uttarakhand, in 2012? People and their homes were washed away in an instant. Over 4,000 people died. That day in June 2012, we watched the terrible climate catastrophe in Nepal.

This is a moment for all of us in India to pause. While we mourn the loss of lives, we must also consider how to prevent such an event in our own part of the Himalayas. We, too, are highly vulnerable to climate change. The first thing India must do is acknowledge that the Himalayas are a young, fragile mountain range. Perhaps, as is being suggested now, the entire range might be slowly destabilising as temperatures rise and glaciers melt.

I would propose three key

steps — not to do, but to undo — all based on existing knowledge and studies.

First, rethink how towns and infrastructure in these belts are being developed, in the context of the landscape's carrying capacity. Where needed, undo what has been built before nature does the needful. Second, reimagine and limit tourism. It is not viable for people to drive into the hills, dance, eat instant noodles and return. Even pilgrimages are not supposed to be instant. A pilgrim is expected to take their time, make an effort and then, finally, be blessed with a duration. Third, build livelihoods that keep the region stable and resilient. Invest in this zealously. The Himalayas, in the coming years, need a brave new vision if they are to remain intact.

(The writer is the founder and director of Chitwan Environmental Research and Action Group)

400 PASSENGERS RESCUED AFTER HILL SLIP THWARTS TRAIN IN SHIMLA

NEW DELHI: At least 39 passengers and train crew were evacuated to Kalka after a hill slip scuppered operations at the Kalka-Shimla route, leaving part of a connecting bridge exposed, Northern Railway said on Sunday. The landslide, caused by incessant rain, undermined a section of the track between Koti and Ghumman stations on the Shimla-Kalka UNESCO World Heritage section, Northern Railway officials executed a prompt and seamless rescue operation, ensuring zero inconvenience to travellers, a Railway press note said.

Four incoming trains were short-terminated in the wake of the accident. The train crew were descending after summiting Mount Nun (7,135 metres). The Leh-Badshahi Hqs 14 Corps called a "daring high-altitude casualty evacuation" while sharing the skill and courage of the Army Aviation Corps, officials added.

The development came three months after a Chetanki helicopter near Leh's Tange area on May 20. The two pilots — a lieutenant colonel and a major — and the third occupant Major General Sachin Mehta, General Officer Commanding of the Karu-based 31st Infantry Division, miraculously survived the crash with minor injuries. Equipped with a modern and fuel-efficient TM33-32M2 engine, the Chetanki features an automatic back-up engine control system. The Chetanki project began about 25 years ago to enhance high-altitude operational capabilities, improve maintainability, and provide a mid-life upgrade for safe and reliable operations.

The Leh-based Hqs 14 Corps, responsible for operations in the sector, operates around 25 Chetankis, a re-engineered version of the workhorse Chetanki helicopter.

Army Chetanki carries out daring mission in Ladakh

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NEW DELHI: Two Indian Army pilots pushed their single-engine Chetanki helicopter to its limits to evacuate an injured mountaineer near the Nun-Kun peaks in Ladakh's Zaskar range, landing at 18,600 feet with just one skid barely touching the treacherous snow-sloped, officials aware of the matter said on Sunday.

The pilots braved extreme weather and unforgiving terrain to evacuate the injured junior commissioned officer on Saturday but despite their efforts, the soldier succumbed to his injuries at an army hospital in Kargil, the officials said.

He was part of an army mountaineering team that was descending after summiting Mount Nun (7,135 metres). The Leh-based Hqs 14 Corps called a "daring high-altitude casualty evacuation" while sharing the skill and courage of the Army Aviation Corps, officials added.

The development came three months after a Chetanki helicopter near Leh's Tange area on May 20. The two pilots — a lieutenant colonel and a major — and the third occupant Major General Sachin Mehta, General Officer Commanding of the Karu-based 31st Infantry Division, miraculously survived the crash with minor injuries. Equipped with a modern and fuel-efficient TM33-32M2 engine, the Chetanki features an automatic back-up engine control system. The Chetanki project began about 25 years ago to enhance high-altitude operational capabilities, improve maintainability, and provide a mid-life upgrade for safe and reliable operations.

The Leh-based Hqs 14 Corps, responsible for operations in the sector, operates around 25 Chetankis, a re-engineered version of the workhorse Chetanki helicopter.

OFFICIALS SAID THE PILOTS BRAVED EXTREME WEATHER AND TERRAIN IN AN ATTEMPT TO SAVE INJURED SOLDIER

Indian Army Aviation pilots evacuated a casualty from an extremely challenging slope with no landing space and strong winds. With the helicopter lighted by removing non-essential equipment and carrying limited fuel, the aviators executed the evacuation with exceptional precision, courage and determination, including a hard landing with one skid touching the slope," the Corps HQs said. The mission was undertaken during the last available landing window of the day, highlighting

the skill and courage of the Army Aviation Corps, officials added.

The development came three months after a Chetanki helicopter near Leh's Tange area on May 20. The two pilots — a lieutenant colonel and a major — and the third occupant Major General Sachin Mehta, General Officer Commanding of the Karu-based 31st Infantry Division, miraculously survived the crash with minor injuries. Equipped with a modern and fuel-efficient TM33-32M2 engine, the Chetanki features an automatic back-up engine control system. The Chetanki project began about 25 years ago to enhance high-altitude operational capabilities, improve maintainability, and provide a mid-life upgrade for safe and reliable operations.

The Leh-based Hqs 14 Corps, responsible for operations in the sector, operates around 25 Chetankis, a re-engineered version of the workhorse Chetanki helicopter.

The army is looking at a swift replacement of its ageing Chetanki and Chetanki, helicopters designed six decades ago. A string of crashes has led to scrutiny of the choppers' safety record.

The army will begin phasing out the fleet in a year or two and replace them with new light utility helicopters (LUHs) over the next eight to 10 years, as part of the Army Aviation Corps' drive to modernise its capabilities. The planned two-pronged replacement approach involves inducting locally produced LUHs and leasing similar choppers as a stopgap to meet critical requirements. The army needs around 250 new helicopters.

Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) licence-produced G25 Chetanki and Chetanki choppers for use across defence services. It no longer builds them but is responsible for their maintenance and repair.

Justice Bhuyan: Why no 'distinguished jurist' appointed to SC?

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NEW DELHI: Supreme Court Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday questioned why the constitutional provision expressly provides for a "distinguished jurist" as an apex court judge has remained unused for more than 76 years, suggesting that the Centre and, later, the collegium had either failed to find a centric point in Indian legal academia or had simply never seriously explored the possibility.

Addressing the 13th convocation of the National Law University, Delhi's Master of Laws (LLM) programme, the top court judge said that Article 24(3) of the Constitution expressly provides for the appointment of a person who, in the President's opinion, is a "distinguished jurist" as a Supreme Court judge. Yet, he noted, no legal academic has so far been appointed to the post.

"There can be two reasons for this unused mandate of the Constitution," said Justice Bhuyan, identifying one possible reason: the view that there was "not enough depth

in the Indian academia" to consider an academic for elevation, and alternatively, that the Centre and the collegium "have not seriously explored this provision thus far".

He said the Constituent Assembly had consciously envisaged academics and jurists as part of the Supreme Court, pointing to the debates in which HV Kamath and M. Ananthasaynam Ayyangar supported widening the field beyond judges and advocates. Ayyangar had suggested that a "distinguished jurist" could be a law professor or dean of a university, while citing the appointment of Harvard professor Felix Frankfurter to the US Supreme Court as an example.

Justice Bhuyan rejected as "very shallow" the argument that legal academics lack the practical experience necessary to become judges. The Supreme Court, he said, was the highest judicial body but its "moral, legal and constitutional conscience keeper" and the inclusion of distinguished jurists was intended to bring diversity to the Bench and bring academic scholarship to

the highest level of judicial decision-making.

He also pointed to jurisdictions such as the US, UK, Canada and Kenya where academics have been appointed to constitutional benches. In the US, he noted, several Supreme Court justices, including Frankfurter, Antonin Scalia, Ruth Bader Ginsburg and Stephen Breyer, had teaching backgrounds. In the UK, former Supreme Court President Lord Hale and Justice Andrew Burrows were among those with substantial academic careers before their judicial appointments.

"It is regrettable that this provision has remained one of our Constitution's unused mandates," lamented Justice Bhuyan, adding that the issue required "serious attention".

Universities spaces for dissent: difficult questions

Justice Bhuyan's remarks on the untapped potential of legal academia came alongside a broader defence of universities as spaces for free thought, dissent and dissent — themes that acquire particular resonance amid the recent friction between law students, university administrations and the legal establishment. "The most valuable quality that legal education can give you is not simply the ability to know the law but the courage to question, to challenge established assumptions and to ask whether the law in its application in a particular way has served the cause of justice," he told the graduating students.

He said asking questions was only the beginning, because a healthy academic environment must also allow people to engage with answers that differ from their

own. "It allows different views to be expressed, examined and debated," he said, stressing that democratic society could not be built on the assumption that everyone would think alike.

The comments came days after a major controversy involving the Bar Council of India, NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad and Chief Justice of India Surya Kant. The BCI, headed by Manoj Kumar Mishra, had on August 13 directed state bar councils not to enrol NALSAR's 2026 graduating batch as advocates amid a campaign by students opposing the BCI's proposed participation as chief guest at their convocation.

The directive was withdrawn within hours following criticism from the Supreme Court, hearing a challenge to the BCI's action, strongly questioned the intervention, with CJI Kant observing that students had a right to peaceful protest and questioning what business the BCI had in intervening in what he described as a dialogue between the students and the government.

He said the students were engaged to law students, saying he

regretted if anything connected to the controversy, including his words or letter, had hurt their feelings. He also acknowledged that students' concerns deserved to be heard "with patience, sensitivity and respect".

The episode also spilled over to the National Law School of India University in Bengaluru, where students and alumni objected to the presence of NALSAR and CJI Surya Kant at its convocation and demanded an apology from the BCI chairman over the NALSAR episode. The university subsequently cancelled its 2026 convocation amid the controversy.

Close on the heels of these developments, Justice Bhuyan underlined that constitutional democracy required institutions to accommodate differences rather than treat every dissent as a threat. "The freedom to express an opinion to disagree with, including his view and to participate in public life would be meaningful only when there is space for dissent." The judge described tolerance not merely as a matter of courtesy but as a constitutional value, citing

Justice O Chinnappa Reddy's observations in *Kannan*, where he said, "our Constitution prescribes tolerance." A democracy's maturity, he said, was reflected not merely in how it treated popular opinion in moments of crisis but in how it responded to views that were "difficult, unpopular or inconvenient".

"A university is not merely an institution that transfers knowledge from one generation to another," said the SC judge, adding it should be a place where established positions could be questioned and disagreements take place through reason rather than hostility. "It should be a space where an idea is not accepted merely because it is familiar and where student does not hesitate to ask difficult questions simply because the answer may be uncomfortable," he added.

For law students and future lawyers, academics and judges, he said, this freedom carried a particular responsibility: to ensure that liberty, equality, dignity and justice remained at the centre of the law in moments of disagreement, dissent and conflict.

DCGA flagged safety issues with Tecnam aircraft before P crash

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LUCKNOW: Aviation regulator DCGA had flagged safety issues concerning Tecnam aircraft over a month before a Tecnam P2006T training aircraft crashed in Kanpur on August 27, killing a trainee pilot and an instructor.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) had also issued safety recommendations to flying training organisations (FTOs) concerning the Tecnam aircraft and asked them to implement them with immediate effect. According to official communications accessed and reviewed by PTL, the DCGA had at least twice since 2025 flagged concerns over Tecnam planes, primarily used in India for flying training, with FTOs.

The latest communication, dated July 10, 2026, circulated safety recommendations issued by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) following the May 12, 2022 crash of a twin-engine Tecnam P2006T, operated by PTC Flying School Pvt Ltd, at Bhilwani in Haryana.

In the email, the regulator advised FTOs to "avoid parking Tecnam aircraft on apron/tar-



The Tecnam training aircraft crashed in Kanpur on August 27, killing a trainee pilot and an instructor.

mac for prolonged periods during the summer season prior to commencing training flights".

It also said, "Greater emphasis should be placed on training for handling emergency situations, particularly during critical phases of flight on Tecnam aircraft." The DCGA further directed that "checklists should be revised to explicitly incorporate all Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEM)-recommended actions for handling emergency situations".

The communication was based on the final investigation report, which was available on the

ity, said several instructors had faced difficulties. "Diamond and Cessna aircraft, which have traditionally been flown for a long time, have good reliability, maintenance and airworthiness. Tecnam aircraft are becoming more popular because of their affordability, but there is a flying risk associated with them," the instructor said.

The senior pilot trainer said the concerns extended to both single-engine and multi-engine Tecnam aircraft and claimed that incidents involving the aircraft were not always reflected clearly in available records.

The instructor also referred to the 2022 Bhilwani accident and the findings of the subsequent AAI investigation, saying they pointed to difficulties associated with operating Tecnam aircraft.

The instructor suggested the DCGA should consider ground-based AAI investigation and allow FTOs to operate them only after their safety and airworthiness had been fully assessed. A Tecnam P2006T crashed during an address in Kanpur on August 27.

The aircraft had taken off from Kanpur Civil Airport

around 11.30 am and crashed about 20 minutes later near Nathapuri village in the Katni area along the Ganga.

Instructor Sachin Bhatia and trainee pilot Abhishek Pujari were killed in the latest crash. "Gang Bhatia was a good pilot and an experienced flying instructor. The images of the wreckage of his plane that circulated on social media shortly after the incident reflected something unusual," the instructor told PTL.

"The damage to the aircraft was not as severe in the Bhilwani crash of 2022 although it was the same make aircraft, but here the whole fuselage has gone leaving only the tail of the plane," the instructor added.

The ministry of civil aviation said the AAI would conduct a detailed investigation into the accident, while a three-member DCA team would provide regulatory oversight and coordination. The investigation is expected to examine the aircraft's maintenance and airworthiness records, flying hours, age and engine operating limits, besides determining whether technical or human factors contributed to the crash.

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday called for a drug-free India and urged young people, musicians, students, theatre groups and content creators to use their creativity to spread awareness against addiction, as he focused on youth and women.

"Drug addiction does not just limit monthly radio programme 'Mann Ki Baat', the Prime Minister said. The 'Nasha-mukt Yuva for Viksit Bharat' campaign is currently gaining momentum across the nation. Its goal is absolutely clear: drug-free youth is a drug-free India."

He said the campaign had received significant participation, particularly from youngsters, and stressed the wider impact of drug addiction.

"Drug addiction does not just engulf a single individual; the entire family and society has to bear the consequences," he said.

Modi called on youngsters to create content to support the campaign. "Our country has no shortage of excellent content creators. I urge them to create content in various languages



Narendra Modi

that helps society in this endeavor. You can use your creativity as a medium for social change," he said, urging people to share their efforts using the hashtag #NashaMuktYuva.

He further highlighted women's economic empowerment through the PM SVANidhi scheme, noting that women account for approximately 46% of its beneficiaries, translating into around 3.5 million women expanding their businesses under the scheme. He cited Babita Sharma of Ghaziabad, who expanded her stall selling flowers, earthen lamps, incense sticks and other worship items into a proper shop after receiving assistance through PM SVANidhi. He also spoke of S.N. Nimmanga of Bengaluru,

who expanded her idli, dosa and sambar business after receiving support under the scheme.

"When a woman's business grows, the future of her entire family advances along with it," Modi said. "This is, indeed, a living example of women's empowerment," he added.

Modi also highlighted Mission ShaktiSAT, through which 12,000 girl students from 108 countries are getting an opportunity to learn satellite technology and innovation.

"The goal of this entire initiative is truly special: preparation for the future. India is under way to send a satellite - developed entirely through the participation of female students - into lunar orbit in the coming year."

Modi also urged citizens to embrace "Vocal for Local" during the upcoming festive season, saying the idea goes beyond the sharing of Sone river water should extend to all products purchased from homes.

"Whatever item we purchase for our homes, do ensure to see that it is made in India," he said, urging influencers, celebrities and people from the creative world to promote the message of self-reliance.

'PURIFICATION' ROW: FIR LODGED AGAINST RAHUL GANDHI

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HALDWAN/DEHRADUN: A first information report (FIR) was registered on Sunday against leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi at Haldwani Kotwali police station in Uttarakhand's Nainital district over his alleged remarks over a "purification ritual" conducted at the local Ramlika Ground.

Superintendent of Police (C) Haldwani Manoj Kumar Katyal confirmed the development, saying, "Based on the complaint submitted by Amit Kumar, a Jawahar Nagar Colony resident, an FIR has been registered against Rahul Gandhi over remarks made during a purification ritual at the local Ramlika Ground."

The case has been registered under section 153B (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989 and Sections 106 (promoting enmity between classes) and 299 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023.

The complainant has alleged that during a procession in New Delhi on August 29, Gandhi wrongly described the cleansing and waxen ritual as an act of "untouchability" and an atrocity against the Scheduled Caste community without verifying the facts.

2 held in Manipur after body parts of woman found in train from TN

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CHENNAI/IMPAL: Police have arrested a couple in the Manipur Jiribam district in connection with the murder of a 38-year-old woman in Tamil Nadu's Guduvanchery, officers said on Sunday, nearly a month after the victim's dismembered body was found in a suitcase on a Delhi-bound train.

Police identified the accused as Manik Udum Laskar, 22, of Assam's Cachar district, and his wife, Bhagabati Majhi, alias Ayesha Begum, 21, of Odisha's Kendughar district.

"A joint team of Tamil Nadu Police, assisted by Manipur Police, arrested Manik on the inter-village road between Lalpani and Raddipudi in Manipur's Jiribam district on August 28. Co-accused Bhagabati was arrested the following day from Kashiampur village in the same district," a Manipur Police statement said.

Manipur Police added that the couple were being handed over to the station house officer of the Guduvanchery police station in Tamil Nadu for further formalities.

Chennai Government Railway Police superintendent of police P Rajan said on Sunday that the couple would be produced before a magistrate in Manipur before being brought to Chennai.

JU WHITEWASHES POLITICAL GRAFFITI IN CAMPUS AFTER WB CM'S REBUKE

KOLKATA: Political graffiti on the walls of Kolkata's Jadavpur University (JU) was whitewashed after chief minister Svendula Adhikari, during an address outside the campus, said that his government would not allow JU to become a free ground for Maoist and Palestinian sympathisers and elements seeking Kashmir's independence.

The development comes amid unrest at the university following clashes between the ABVP and SFI last week.

A professor, who requested anonymity, said, "A contractor hired by the university's maintenance department covered most of the graffiti with white paint on Sunday morning. The authorities do not want the university to be drawn into a controversy."

The whitewashed graffiti included pro-Palestine, anti-Nazi and anti-fascist messages.

The SFI's Jadavpur unit announced via a social media post on Sunday evening that it would hold a protest on Monday to oppose the university's action.

State sports and youth services minister Dr Indranil Khan, said, "JU is widely acknowledged as a centre of excellence. The campus should be free of radical politics," he said.

CPJM leader Bikash Banjan Bhattacharya, a former Kolkata mayor, criticised the move, and said, "Campuses are where young people are educated, think freely and exchange ideas. No whitewashing can stop that," Bhattacharya said.

After 25 yrs, Bihar, J'khand to ink Sone pact

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NEW DELHI: Bihar and Jharkhand on Monday will sign an agreement formalising the sharing of Sone river water, resolving the dispute that has persisted since 1973. Jharkhand has carved out of Bihar in 2000.

"All details had already been finalised. Chief ministers of both states are coming to sign the pact Monday," a senior Union Jai Shakti ministry official told HT, on condition of anonymity.

OF THE 7.75 MAF OF SONE RIVER WATER ORIGINALLY ALLOCATED TO BIHAR, 5.75 MAF WILL NOW GO TO BIHAR AND 2.0 MAF TO JHARKHAND

HT had on July 24 reported that the agreement was very close to be signed after both states completed their internal approvals. The development comes after Jharkhand in July passed the matter in its cabinet earlier this month.

The agreement settles the division of the erstwhile undivided Bihar's allocation under the 1973 Bangsagar Agreement. Of the total 7.75 million acre-feet (MAF) of Sone river water originally allocated to Bihar, 5.75 MAF will now go to Bihar and the remaining 2.0 MAF of water to Jharkhand. The allocation follows the unanimous recommendation of a committee constituted by the Centre under the chairmanship of the Central Water Commission to resolve the long-pending issue.

The Bangsagar Agreement, signed in 1973 between Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and the then undivided Bihar, governs the sharing of Sone river water. While the agreement continued after Jharkhand was carved out in November 2000, the division of the share between the two successor states had remained unresolved for nearly 25 years.

Jamshedpur to lose flight connectivity from tomorrow

JAMSHEDPUR: Jharkhand's second largest city, Jamshedpur will lose air connectivity after Monday with the India One Air, after stopping it's Jamshedpur-Jamshedpur-Jamshedpur flight from Tuesday due to unviable business of operating with smaller aircraft and lack of subsidy on fare by the state or the Central governments.

"Our last flight from Jamshedpur to Kolkata was on Monday. Even after tenders were floated on Monday and the service will be stopped from Tuesday. We had no option because operating 9-seater aircraft was not viable without fare subsidy," Prem Kumar Garg, CEO of the India One Air, told HT.

Keralam man drowns in culvert in C'garh, his friend rescued

AMBIKAPUR: A 23-year-old Keralam man drowns after being swept away while crossing a swollen culvert on a motorcycle in Changanassari district, a police officer said on Sunday.

His 22-year-old friend, who was riding pillion, also fell into the water. The local residents rescued her, saying, adding that she is recovering in a hospital.

The two from Keralam had arrived in Ambikapur, the headquarters of Surguja district, on Friday. They had gone to Mainpat on a motorcycle on Saturday. Kameshwarwar police station house officer Manoj Prajapati said.

4 killed in collision between mini bus and truck in Assam

GUWAHATI: At least four people were killed and seven others injured in a head-on collision between a mini bus and a truck in Assam's Kamrup Metropolitan district on Sunday, police said.

According to Guwahati Police Additional Deputy Commissioner (Traffic) Saiful Hussain, the accident took place on National Highway-27 at Tetelia near Sonapur in the evening.

"The mini bus was coming towards Guwahati and the truck was headed in the opposite direction. The truck was under control. The driver lost control of the bus, and hit the truck," Hussain added.

NEWBORN AMONG 3 OF FAMILY KILLED, THREE INJURED IN BIKANER ACCIDENT

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BIKANER: A two-day-old was among three people killed when a car collided with a truck in Rajasthan's Bikaner district, police said on Sunday, adding the other three were injured.

The accident occurred on Saturday evening near Bhadal village when the family was returning home after the mother and her newborn were discharged from a hospital.

The family from Madasav village in Phalodi was travelling in the car when it collided with a truck, and a man died in the incident, while the baby's mother Badhu Devi, her maternal uncle Manish and his wife Manju Devi sustained critical injuries, police said. The injured are admitted to PBM Hospital.

In a separate incident reported from Hanumanagar, three people were killed in a collision between a jeep and a scooter on the Pilibanga-Rawat-sar road late on Saturday evening, police said.

Reator's body found in UP canal, probe on

Lucknow: A 45-year-old property dealer was allegedly abducted and murdered in Lucknow, with police suspecting a dispute involving land in Unnao as a possible motive. The body was recovered from a canal near Dubagga on Sunday, more than 22 km from the place where he was allegedly abducted.

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What Delhi can learn from TN on rental housing

Soumya Chatterjee
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NEW DELHI: To accommodate the large number of migrant workers arriving in the city, the newly notified Master Plan for Delhi 2047 has incorporated rental housing into the city's statutory planning framework for the first time.

It also renewed optimism for the Centre's six-year-old initiative to develop formal rental housing, under the flagship Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Urban (PMAY-U), which has resulted in fewer than 10,000 units nationwide, with as many as 40,630 in just one state—Tamil Nadu.

According to Delhi MP 2047, notified last week, Affordable Rental Housing Complexes (ARHC) will come as single-bedroom and double-bedroom units, with carpet area of up to 30 sqm and 60 sqm respectively.

Under the plan, residents will have "licence rights" rather than tenancy rights, with a minimum tenure of three months and a maximum of three years.

Much like Tamil Nadu, the Delhi Master Plan will also allow industrial plots and parks to be used for worker housing and rental housing, and they will be permitted under upcoming unauthorised-colony regeneration schemes.

ARHC's limited progress

The Delhi framework is being introduced against a backdrop of limited progress under the Centre's ARHC sub-scheme, carved out of the PMAY-U in 2020 specifically to provide cheap, dignified rental units close to workplaces for migrants who cannot buy homes because of high costs and low incomes, officials said. He said the trend will watch on as more and more companies with experience operating in Southeast Asia expand their operations in India.

Delhi and Maharashtra, which together account for 61,457 identified vacant houses, illustrate the same pattern.

The ministry told a parliamentary panel that the scheme was "not feasible" for conversion "due to various reasons", without specifying what those reasons were.

Justice Rohinton F. Khare of the Human Rights India, which helps beneficiaries access formal finance for such housing, said that in most cases, the reason is the high cost of land. "It is a huge barrier for conversion," he said, adding that the government is not doing enough to bring down the cost of land.

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AAP worker shot dead in Pb; old dispute likely

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FEROZEPUR: A 45-year-old Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) worker was killed, and his associate sustained bullet injuries in a shooting in Punjab's Ferozepur district, police said on Sunday, suspecting that the attack stemmed from an old dispute or a political rivalry.

The incident took place on Saturday night when Gurpreet Singh Gopi was travelling with his associate Harpreet. The



The Master Plan for Delhi 2047 has incorporated rental housing into the city's statutory planning framework for the first time.

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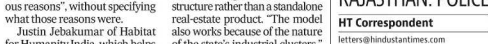
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incentives and regulatory support, private-sector participation is likely to stay limited. He said the trend will watch on as more and more companies with experience operating in Southeast Asia expand their operations in India.

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4 DROWN IN POND NEAR TEMPLE IN RAJASTHAN: POLICE

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BHARATPUR: Four of a family allegedly drowned in a pond near a temple in Rajasthan's Bharatpur district on Sunday, police said.

The incident took place around 4 am near the Heeraam Baba temple in Bijra village, where a family of five was bathing. A man identified as Ravi Singh, 21, went to the pond for a bath and started drowning. Singh was accompanied by his three sisters—Manoma, 22, and Boto, 20—and their cousin Kala, 18—who tried to save their brother, but all four were swept away.

Angal police station assistant sub-inspector Mohan Singh said the four had gone to the pond to bathe before visiting the temple. The three women drowned while attempting to rescue Ravi after he entered deep water," Singh said, adding that their bodies were handed over to their families for post-mortem examinations.

[OPPN TAKES SWIPE AT BHAGWAT'S U.S. SPEECH]

Wise words abroad, but silence at home: Sibal

Press Trust of India
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NEW DELHI: Rajya Sabha MP Kapil Sibal on Sunday took a swipe at RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat over his remarks in the US that unity in diversity is in Bharat's DNA, saying words don't come to politicians must speak. Sibal, who is a senior advocate and an Independent Rajya Sabha MP, slammed Bhagwat's comments and said it was a case of "wise words abroad" but "silence at home". Bhagwat in New York "diversity is a decoration of our innate unity. It has to be protected. Wise words abroad, silence at home. Words don't come to politicians must speak" Sibal said on X.

Addressing over 6,000 members of the Indian-American community at a mega rally in New York on Saturday, Bhagwat gave a clarion call to embrace diversity and support communi-



Kapil Sibal, Mohan Bhagwat

ties. "When we say the USA, one of them is often discussed, that is pluralism. And when we say Bharat, another phrase is discussed: unity in diversity". He also said if any Hindu thinks there should be no Muslims in Bharat, he will not remain a Hindu. The Congress, TMC, and other opposition parties said he should convey this to BJP leaders and outfits that "spread hatred between Hindus and Muslims". Congress spokesperson Shama Mohamed said that Bhagwat should "stop lying" and alleged

that the RSS' DNA has "hated and communalism". TMC MP Sakarika Ghose said a "chilling duplicity" was on display and asked Bhagwat not to be "intellectually and morally dishonest".

Defending Bhagwat, senior BJP leader and Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnis said "tolerance runs in the blood of Hindus, and it is a fundamental aspect of Hinduva".

Chief Imam backs RSS chief Meanwhile, the chief Imam of All India Imam Organisation, Imam Umar Ahmed Ilyasi supported Bhagwat's remarks on Hindu-Muslim unity. "I support and am with respected Mohan Bhagwat Ji's statement, and I believe India agrees with it. He has always spoken with it. He has always been against the religious people of other religions. He has said everyone's DNA is the same..." Ilyasi told ANI.

4 KIDS KILLED IN TN AFTER MILK VAN RUNS THEM OVER

S Vijay Karthik
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CHENNAI: Four children, all in the age group of 4 to 11 years, were killed after they were hit by a speeding milk van in Dindigul district on Sunday, police said. The children were playing in the roadside near their house in Kollampatti village of Dindigul district on Sunday afternoon when the incident took place.

The children and a person who was sitting outside his residence, near the accident spot, suffered serious injuries and were taken to district hospital. However, the children died and the person is currently under treatment," police said.

The driver of the vehicle has been taken into custody, they said, adding that a case has been registered. Tamil Nadu chief minister C Joseph Vijay extending condolences to the grieving families on the passing of 13 lakh to the families of the children and 1 lakh to the kin of the injured.

K'taka IAS officer held over irregularities in KPSC exam

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BENGALURU: The Criminal Investigation Department (CID) on Sunday arrested IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar in connection with alleged irregularities in the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) examination for 400 veterinary officer posts, officials familiar with the matter said.

Gangwar, a 2016 batch Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer who is currently Director of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, was the KPSC examination controller from February 2024 to March 2026. He was taken into custody late Saturday after several hours of questioning. Officials said investigators found inconsistencies in his statements and felt he was uncooperative. He was produced before a magistrate on Sunday

GYANENDRA GANGWAR, A 2016 BATCH IAS OFFICER, WAS KPSC EXAMINATION CONTROLLER FROM FEBRUARY '24 TO MARCH '26

and was remanded to judicial custody. He was later taken to Parappana Agrahara prison, they said.

"We took him into custody on Saturday and the arrest was formalised by Sunday afternoon," said an officer familiar with the development. According to officials, Gangwar was questioned for about nine hours in Bengaluru on Friday before the interrogation continued on Saturday. Investigators are examining his role in the

examination's conduct, including the handling of question papers, evaluation and alleged manipulation of OMR answer sheets.

The FIR alleges that Gangwar received ₹1.1 crore from 20 candidates in return for tampering with their OMR sheets. He has been booked under Section 318 (3) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and Section 10 of the Karnataka Public Examination (Measures for Prevention of Corruption & Unfair Means in Recruitment) Act.

The state government transferred the case to the CID on July 28 after two cases were registered at Vidhana Soudha police station. The complaint was filed by veterinarian Manjunath against suspected former KPSC chairman Shivashankarappa S Sahukara and others.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is separately examining the alleged irregularities in the exam.

K'TAKA MIN: ISLAM 'GREATER' THAN OTHER RELIGIONS

KOPPAL: Karnataka higher education minister Basavaraj Rayar-eddi on Sunday said Islam is "greater" than other religions, and also expressed his desire to visit Mecca, but claimed that he cannot do so as a non-Muslim.

"I would like to say that Islam is shreshtha (supreme) (great religion) than other dharmas..." the minister said while speaking at a Muslim community mass marriage programme in Kuk-noor in Koppal district.

He also said he has tried to study the Quran and other religions and his history. Stating that Islam is highly disciplined, highly scientific, and the most humane religion, he said, "Read it, understand, and don't become bigots, don't become casteists. There are good and bad people in all religions, but bad things are always highlighted... We should respect all religions. We should know good things in all religions as religions are for well being of mankind and we should try to do good."

BJP hit back at the Congress, with leader of Opposition R Ashoka saying: "CM Shivakumar, is there no end to the anti-Hindu mindset of your Congress government?"

Govt notifies rules for IST as common time

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NEW DELHI: The government has notified the Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026, mandating Indian Standard Time (IST) as the single reference for legal, administrative, commercial and other official purposes across the country.

The nodal consumer affairs ministry notified the rules on August 27 but they'll come into force 180 days after their publication in the official gazette, giving government departments, businesses, and institutions time to align their systems.

The move comes amid growing reliance on digital and technology-based systems -- from banking and payments to telecommunications, railways, power grids and computer networks -- that depend on accurate and synchronised time stamps.

The ministry said inconsistencies between different time sources currently in use could affect

THE MOVES COME AS DIGITAL AND TECHNOLOGY-BASED SYSTEMS DEPEND ON ACCURATE AND SYNCHRONISED TIME STAMPS

the coordination and recording of such activities, prompting the push for a uniform national time standard.

The common time reference is expected to support accurate time-stamping of banking and digital payment transactions, coordination among railways, airports and other transport systems, reliable functioning of telecommunication and internet networks, precise time-keeping in power systems, and government and legal records, and coordination of emergency and other time-critical services, the ministry said in a statement.

[ADVIAANI]

Centre's initiative takes tribal languages online

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NEW DELHI: The Union government has developed an artificial intelligence (AI)-powered language platform seeking to include tribal communities in the country's digital transformation by getting hundreds of tribal languages online and providing benefits to people in their own languages.

India has more than 700 tribal communities and over 100 tribal languages and dialects. Yet only a small proportion of these languages have a script, dictionary or substantial digital presence.

AdiVaani, developed under the ministry of tribal affairs in collaboration with IIT Delhi, enables translation and transcription of Hindi, English and tribal languages through text and speech. The platform currently supports Santali, Mundari, Bhilli and Gondi, with Kuli

and Garo among the languages being taken up next. Its next phase envisages adding more languages and significantly expanding verified speech recordings, with collections expected to run into hundreds of thousands of samples for individual languages.

The initiative is aimed not merely at translation but at making government services, healthcare information, educational material and other digital resources accessible to people in languages they use in everyday life, through text-to-text translation, automatic speech recognition, text-to-speech and speech-to-speech functions.

"Language cannot become a barrier to accessing the benefits of development," said Ranjana Khosla, secretary, ministry of tribal affairs, stressing the need to ensure that technology reaches communities in forms they can understand and use.

CIP ACTIVISTS VISIT TWO RAJ SCHOOLS, THREATEN STIR IF INFRA NOT FIXED

HT Correspondent
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JAIPUR: Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) activists on Sunday inspected two government primary schools in the Shastri Nagar-Bhatra Best area and alleged that both lacked basic infrastructure, giving the administration seven days to address the deficiencies.

The inspection came around 10 days after members of the group were allegedly attacked during a visit to dilapidated government school in Bagru.

In a statement, the CJP claimed that the completed building of one government primary school had remained closed for several years, forcing local children to travel long distances to attend classes.

The group said the second school was operating from a makeshift, cage-like structure without a proper building, it said.

State education minister Madan Dilwadi did not respond to requests for comment.

NEET-PG test conducted, probe ordered into snag at two Centres in Jaipur

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JAIPUR/NEW DELHI: The National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) conducted the NEET-PG examination on Sunday even as it constituted a three-member committee to investigate the internal power supply failure that disrupted exam at two ION Digital Zone centres in Sitapura in Jaipur, Rajasthan, officials said.

Exam coordinator Narendra Verma said around 2,400 candidates were taking the computer-based examination at both the centres. Candidates alleged that repeated power outages and technical glitches interrupted the test as many as 10 times within two hours.

The examination was scheduled from 9am to 12.30pm. According to the candidates, the test could resume only around 10am after the initial disruption, but several computer systems continued to malfunction.

Hundreds of candidates protested outside the centre after the examination.

According to officials, the three-member panel will examine the circumstances leading to the power failure and ascertain the reasons for the disruption.

"The committee will examine the matter and submit its report within the stipulated timeframe," a source said.

The NEET-PG test was scheduled for 273,096 candidates at 111 examination centres across 359 cities, covering all 36 states and Union Territories. A total of 265,980 candidates appeared for the examination, with the examination successfully completed for approximately 263,535 candidates, the NBEMS said.

The nationwide examination was supported by extensive real-time monitoring and stringent security measures. Sixteen NBEMS Regional Command Centres were operational across the country for a fair and smooth conduct of the exam, NBEMS said.

TN BUSINESSMAN, TWO AIDES, HELD UNDER POCSO ACT

CHENNAI: An 80-year-old prominent granite businessman from Tamil Nadu and two of his aides were arrested by the Central Crime Branch's (CCB) anti-sexual assault unit for allegedly sexually assaulting a minor girl, police said on Sunday.

The case was lodged on October 6, 2025, after a volunteer filed a complaint with the CCB and submitted a pen drive. The man claimed that the pen drive contained footage of prominent businessman 84-year old R Veeramani committing a sexual offence against a young girl in the bed room of his associate, Shanthi in Teynampet in Chennai," a press release from CCB said on Sunday.

Police arrested Veeramani, Shanthi and Mahendra Simhan late on Saturday, the release said. Despite repeated attempts, a representative of the businessman's family did not respond to calls.

ED ON NEET LEAK

Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002. People familiar with the matter said the agency is seeking to, after the CBI material, while it waits for the ongoing court proceedings in the CBI case to conclude.

"We definitely want to investigate a criminal angle in the NEET-UG paper leak, but we will wait for CBI's court proceedings to get over, which are currently ongoing in the fast-track court in Delhi," an official said, requesting anonymity. "For now, we have approached the CBI through proper official channels for its charge sheet, relied-upon documents and other case files so that we can study the alleged irregularities," the official added.

The CBI filed its charge sheet earlier this month against all 13 people arrested in the case, saying its investigation had traced the alleged leak from the paper setters to beneficiary candidates and uncovered the alleged conspiracy.

The three paper setters arrested by the National Testing Agency (NTA) -- Manisha Gurnath Mandhare for Botany and Zoology, Prathal Vithal Kulkarni for Chemistry, and Manisha Sanjay Havaldar for Physics -- have been named as accused in the case.

According to the CBI charge sheet, Kulkarni allegedly transcribed 35 Chemistry questions, along with their answer options, onto small pieces of paper and took them out of the control room area. Havaldar and Mandhare allegedly memorised questions and their parameters and later reconstructed them with the help of their assistants according to the agency's case.

The CBI has invoked provisions relating to criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust and deserting of evidence, besides provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act and the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024. The agency has relied on 360 witnesses, 422 documents and 43 material objects to support its case. All 13 people named in the charge sheet are in judicial custody, while the CBI is continuing its further investigation.

The CBI has so far said that no NTA official has been found involved in the alleged leak. The government has subsequently announced changes to the NTA's examination system. The education ministry said on August 17 that more than 50

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

NTA staff had been removed and 10 professional leadership positions were being filled. The NTA subsequently said its examination team had been revamped, with 600 subject experts removed and new experts brought in, besides the introduction of a four-tier question-paper scrutiny system.

MODI IN UZBEKISTAN The supply of uranium to India. "We are signing in the signing of an agreement very shortly," he said without giving details.

Modi said the two countries will also establish a coordination council by the foreign ministers to provide direction to all aspects of cooperation, and elevate an existing joint commission from the level of secretaries to the ministerial level.

Mirziyoyev described India as a "reliable strategic partner" and noted that New Delhi's voice and influence in global affairs has grown. Joint ventures between the two countries have increased seven-fold and there are now 14 direct flights every week, he said.

"We are aiming to advance cooperation in sectors such as energy, culture, critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, jewellery and agriculture," Mirziyoyev said.

"We will prepare roadmaps for each of these sectors. Specific teams from India will come here, and our teams will travel to India, enabling us to clearly define our objectives in these fields," he added.

Mirziyoyev said the introduction of a 30-day visa-free regime between the two countries is a significant contribution to developing tourism and business exchanges.

Modi pointed out that the close defence and security cooperation between the two sides "reflects the deep mutual trust that underpins our relationship". The two countries will promote direct linkages, co-production and co-development between their defence industries, he said.

"We believe that terrorism, extremism and separatism pose serious challenges to the entire region," Modi said. "Our shared resolve to adopt a policy of zero tolerance towards them has been, and will continue to be, unwavering."

An MoU between the ministries of finance of India and Uzbekistan will establish an Economic and Financial Dialogue, while another MoU focuses on cooperation in higher education and scientific research. The external affairs ministry and the Cultural Heritage Agency of Uzbekistan finalised a letter of intent for conserving and restoring the ancient Buddhist sites of Fayaz Tepa and Karakul at Termez.

India announced a grant of \$1 million for afforestation in the Aral Sea region, while India's NIPF International Payments Ltd (NIPF) signed a commercial agreement with Uzbekistan's National Interbank Processing Centre JSC (NIPC) to enable Indian QFI apps of to scan national QR codes for merchant payments in Uzbekistan. Google described this agreement as the first step towards greater interoperability between the digital payment eco-systems of the two countries.

Mirziyoyev conferred the Oliy Darajali Do'slik Order, Uzbekistan's highest honour for foreign leaders, on Modi for his contribution to strengthening the friendship between the two countries. Modi dedicated the award to the 14 billion people of India and said the two sides will work jointly to protect the interests of the Global South.

NEPAL TOLL NEARS 800 ters that residents and rescue workers had moved to higher ground after the Trishuli river's water levels rose in recent hours following fresh rainfall, raising fears of additional flooding.

Rescue operations have been suspended several times since Friday because of bad weather and concerns that a lake formed across the Nepal-China border by the disaster could trigger fresh flooding after it began overflowing in Nepal's Lhunde Khola and Trishuli River.

CHTV reported that the lake threatening downstream areas had been largely drained by Saturday evening. But drones detected a landslide late on Saturday that is 2.8 kilometres (1.7 miles) downstream of the lake, forming a new dam and a fresh pool of water.

rescue operations, DNA testing, refrigerated storage for bodies and forensic identification of decomposed remains.

Days after desperate relatives moved between hospitals, morgues and relief centres searching for loved ones, authorities in Nepal began mass burials of hundreds of unidentified victims whose bodies had started to decompose.

In Chitwan district, which escaped the direct impact of the disaster, bodies swept down stream from the flood-hit Rasuva region have been carried by the river system into the Narayani River.

Authorities are photographing the bodies, collecting DNA samples and recording identifying details in the hope that families may still be able to identify relatives after burial.

"Of the bodies we have recovered so far, more than half are beyond recognition," police officer Anil Thapa told Reuters.

"Many have no visible faces. In some cases, only hands or legs remain; in others, only parts of the body are available. In most cases, more than half of the head is missing."

Before floods, Nepal asked China for early warnings as risks rose Three months before the disaster, experts and officials from Nepal and China met in Kathmandu to discuss the risk of such disasters.

At the May 27 meeting in Nepal's capital, 10 officials from Nepal and about a dozen from China, including the Tibet region where the disaster struck, discussed strengthening cooperation to monitor and respond to floods, weather and glacier-related hazards, according to an agenda prepared by the Nepali side and seen by Reuters.

The participants called for joint risk-reduction measures, including inventories of glacial lakes and hazard mapping.

But two Nepali officials told Reuters they did not receive as much information as they wanted from China on glacier risks and water levels after the meeting and they feared insufficient data sharing could hamper their ability to anticipate and prepare for major disasters.

"What we actually wanted from them, and still want, is if there are any movements of glaciers and early movements around that area, we would want to know a bit early," said Saundhar Joshi, a hydrologist at a Nepal's Flood Forecasting Division, who was at the May meeting.

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{ OUR TAKE }

Blind to toxicity in relationships

Society normalising the power imbalance between men and women contributes to gender-based violence in the country

The fact that the Delhi police has found texts that pointed to a "toxic relationship" between 21-year-old Muskan, and 28-year-old Imran who is accused of murdering her on August 26, is a crucial detail of the investigation that must make us sit up and take notice — not because it offers the rest of us a salacious bit of information about a private relationship between two adults, but because of how easily we accept the fact of its existence in a relationship between two adults.

What exactly happened on the day of the crime, when the life of a budding model and content-creator was tragically cut short, is for the police to investigate and present before the court. Till then — and even afterwards — any assumption about the criminal is a sign of pre-existing bias. To be clear, there is nothing intrinsic about gender-based violence: It exists across caste, class, and religion.

What we must examine, however, is what we consider intrinsic to relationships between adults. Investigation into the deaths of Nikki Bhatti, Twisha Sharma, and Deepika Nagar, to name just a few victims of dowry demands, revealed months of regular harassment and violence that began soon after their weddings. It is our tendency to exceptionalise murder, extreme violence, or rape, but what we allow to exist — and this lies at the root of gender-based violence — is the idea of a fundamental inequality between the genders, which gives one indisputable power over the other. This is not to claim that all relationships are violent, but to assert simply that inequality is a sliding scale of difference. For instance, anthropologists who have studied gender in the subcontinent have found that within the same household, the weight of women's utterances is less than men's when it comes to political/electoral opinions. The researcher was studying voter behaviour during elections, and what leads women to exercise their right to have a say in polity. Now, does this difference in the weight of opinions escalate to gender-based violence? Probably not. But it does lie in all too common belief that inequality is natural and correct.

Make no mistake, relationships where abuse, physical or mental torture, harassment, accusations and possessiveness exist, also operate under the same assumption. Muskan's death points to a deeply disturbing aspect of her life that we, as a society, have repeatedly turned a blind eye towards — that "toxic relationships" are possible because we think it's natural for men to be powerful.

Real state of play for US in Venezuelan oil

On Friday, US President Donald Trump announced that his administration had made an agreement with Venezuela's interim government to secure control of the country's oil reserves — the world's largest, as per current estimates. In keeping with his style, Trump has described the deal as a game-changer for the US economy, which is currently facing high fuel costs because of the war in West Asia. Trump will try his best to portray it as a big achievement before the US mid-term polls in November.

Whether, and more importantly, when, the described benefits materialise for the US economy, is going to be more complicated than what Trump is claiming. Venezuela's oil fields have suffered from decades of mismanagement and will require a massive capital infusion to scale up production as well as profits. Many private oil companies in the US are aware of this challenge and, therefore, have been hesitant to commit to investments in Venezuela.

What further complicates matters is the fact that political instability continues to exist in the Latin American country that saw its authoritarian leader kidnapped in a surprise US operation last year. The interim government, which has made the oil deal with the US, refuses to discuss conducting elections in Venezuela. Even if the US were to succeed in scaling up oil production and profits from Venezuela, the larger question of a superpower arm-twisting a weaker country into offering its precious natural resource will continue to remain. It is interventions like these which triggered a Left upsurge in large parts of Latin America a couple of decades ago. Every such instance underlines the demise of the so-called rules-based world order. It is more about deals than democracy.

{ GRAND STRATEGY }

Happymon Jacob

Ground not covered in talks with China

The pre-2020 status quo has to stay on the table as an Indian demand that will not be given up under any circumstances

The eight-point outcomes that India and China released on Wednesday last week, after the Special Representatives (SRs) of the two countries met in Beijing, signal much-needed diplomatic progress. But they also mask unresolved structural issues on the border dispute. To be sure, the outcomes are better than nothing, but they are also less than what we needed. In a sense, the agreement is also a description of the position India is bargaining from, than what an ideal agreement should have looked like.

The talks between the SRs indicate progress. For instance, two more meeting points for senior commanders, two more hotline channels in the Eastern and Middle sectors, a September meeting on trans-border rivers, three trading points reopened, the pilgrimage expanded, and the next round of talks in India in 2027, are all examples of progress. After the 2020 Galwan standoff and the uncomfortable years that followed, there is little doubt that this is significant progress. My broader concern, however, pertains to what the document doesn't refer to any longer, and what it has

started referring to instead. Let me begin with the silences. A key achievement of more than two decades of SR negotiations, the 2005 Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles, continues to be invoked in the Sino-Indian joint documentation, and it provides great clarity on what a final resolution should entail. Article III of the 2005 Agreement commits both sides to make adjustments to their positions so as to arrive at a "package settlement", and then add a sentence of its own: The boundary settlement must be final, covering all sectors of the Sino-China boundary. That is mandatory language not to be cast aside easily.

Last week's signing by Ajit Doval and Wang Yi reaffirmed the 2005 agreement in point 2, but it does not reaffirm the package deal. To be fair, it does say that the framework will be pursued in accordance with the 2005 agreement in point 2, but it does not reaffirm the package deal. To be fair, it does say that the framework will be pursued in accordance with the 2005 agreement in point 2, but it does not reaffirm the package deal. To be fair, it does say that the framework will be pursued in accordance with the 2005 agreement in point 2, but it does not reaffirm the package deal.

Water-guzzling data centres need treated used water

India's operational data-centre capacity stands at roughly 1.4-1.6 GW (2025) and is projected to reach about 5 GW by 2030. This expansion is backed by close to \$30 billion in committed investment. The current footprint is spread across 300 facilities in 33 states, with very large, new hyperscale clusters announced in Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra. Many cities where these data centres are located are already water-stressed, which is raising concerns. All data centres tend to rely on water-intensive evaporative systems in cooling towers. The quantum of water needed depends on ambient temperature and humidity.

Data centres in India typically consume between 1.5 to 2.5 liters of water per kWh of IT load. A mid-sized 20 MW centre can use approximately 1-1.2 million litres of water daily (MLD), depending on cooling technology and climate conditions. This is not actually a large volume of water, but the demand from multiple hyperscale data centres (>100 MW) in a single city can quickly add up. Importantly, demand will be highest in the hottest and driest months. At a city scale, a data centre cluster could eventually account for 5-10% of municipal water demand, albeit only 1-2% of basin water use. While the basin-level or national footprint looks trivial, at the level of a single stressed city, the demand would compete with supply for domestic use. Conflicts are likely to arise in drought years.

As water evaporates, dissolved minerals and salts get concentrated in the remaining water. At high concentrations, dissolved solids cause scaling and corrosion. Low levels are maintained by adding freshwater to each cycle. To recirculate water many times in a cooling tower, the water source needs to be have a low enough total dissolved solids (TDS) level. Groundwater is typically high in TDS, and if used by data centres, needs additional investment to remove dissolved salts. Alternatively, it has to be used for fewer cycles. This raises data centres' consumption of water.

The current regulatory structure for data centre water use is not specific enough. Data-centre policies in most states are oriented almost entirely towards attracting investment. States offer power tariff concessions, land, stamp-duty waivers, and capital incentives, with data centres enjoying infrastructure status. Water typically appears only as a supply assurance to be promised to investors, not as a common pool resource to be governed.

Water supply is regulated generally through municipal allocations by urban local bodies, and groundwater abstraction via Central Ground Water Authority's no-object certificates. Treated used water (TUV) is a reliable, low TDS source that data centres can benefit from. There is a potential win-win in reusing treated municipal wastewater. Reuse of treated wastewater is encouraged by the National Water Policy and some state reuse policies, but is not yet mandated for data centres. At present, data centres also have standard reporting of

water-use efficiency, source mix, or reuse. This is an opportunity. Around 80% of the water a city supplies returns as sewage. Untreated and partially treated sewage remains one of the biggest pollution threats to urban water bodies. A data centre cluster that treats and reuses 15% of a city's sewage volume will not be adding to the pressure on freshwater at all. Indeed, it will create demand for a waste stream that the city is currently failing to manage. In the absence of such a mandate, the default would be groundwater. Much of India's groundwater, especially across peninsular India's hard-rock aquifers, is unreliable for bulk use. Groundwater levels drop quickly in dry years, with widespread borewell failures during droughts. Sewage, by contrast, is effectively a drought-proof urban water source; people wash, bathe, and use toilets every day, regardless of rainfall. A constant, high-quality source of supply, therefore, could prove highly valuable to a 24x7 data centre.

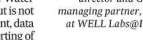
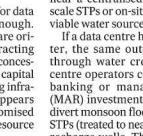
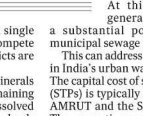
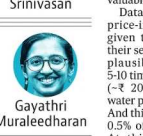
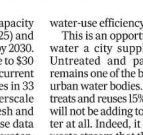
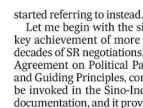
Data centres are relatively price-insensitive, and this has given the monetary value of their services. Operators could plausibly pay up to about 5-10 times the cost of treatment (< ₹ 200-300/L) for treated water polished to a high quality. And this would still be less than 0.5% of their operating costs. At this price, the revenue generated could help defray a substantial portion of the cost of municipal sewage treatment.

This can address the single biggest failure in India's urban water management today. The capital cost of sewage treatment plants (STPs) is typically funded by schemes like AMRUT and the Swachh Bharat Mission. The operations and maintenance costs remain a problem. Many cities are unable to meet these costs. This has led many STPs underutilised or dysfunctional, with effluent flowing untreated into water bodies. If cities price the sale of TUV to data centres appropriately, it could help defray a water security threat into a measurable improvement in river and lake quality. Even where a data centre facility is not situated near a centralised plant, neighbourhood-scale STPs or on-site apartment STPs can be viable water source.

If a data centre has to rely on groundwater, the same outcome can be achieved through water recycling. Specific data centre operators could fund groundwater banking or managed aquifer recharge (MAR) investments. These projects would divert monsoon floodwater, or sewage from STPs (treated to a potable standard), into recharge wells. This would replenish the aquifer they draw on. This would thus offset their abstraction, keeping the net effect neutral-to-positive.

The opportunity here goes beyond water. Data centres can help make Indian cities more liveable. They can become stewards of water resources rather than competitors.

Veena Srinivasan is founder and executive director and Gayathri Muralidharan is managing partner, Urban Water Programme at WELL Labs/IFMR. The views expressed are personal



comes thereafter, in a boundary negotiation, a sector once settled is closed, and what remains on the table is only the ground nobody wanted to give up in the first place.

There is another substantive issue regarding the phrase. If early harvest means beginning where agreement is easiest (to be fair, we do not know yet if this is the case), making concessions in the sectors where agreement comes easily will take us to the harder sectors with a weaker hand, and nothing obliges China to move there at all, except goodwill. If that happens, would there be any incentive for China to concede in the harder sectors once the easier ones are settled?

While the two SRs agreed in 2025 to include "de-escalation" in their joint phraseology, the term is conspicuous by its absence in last week's eight-point document. Military disengagement concluded in October 2024, but de-escalation — withdrawing additional troops deployed to depth areas post-2020 — remains unaddressed. Consequently, the pre-2020 border baseline has not been restored, and the new agreement neither claims to achieve this nor commits to reinstating that status quo.

The same danger may reside in sequencing delimitation ahead of restoration of status quo ante bellum. While talks begin in one sector (or after they conclude), the military balance could shift in another: Infrastructure, deployments and in China's case, the border village pro-



India must maintain constant vigilance and active military presence along the LAC, refusing to lower its guard for vague paper commitments.

gramme continue to change the facts on the ground. Article VII of the 2005 agreement says a settlement must safeguard the due interests of settled populations in the border areas. That clause was traditionally understood in India's favour. But today, it could read differently considering the establishment of Chinese villages in the vicinity.

None of this means that last week's agreement was deeply flawed or has no merits. In reality, the package settlement Article III described in 2005 has produced no framework in 21 years, and certainly did not prevent 2020. If that is the experience of the past two decades, endlessly waiting for a desirable package deal which may or may not arrive might not be a great strategy. The bilateral power differential is widening: India's economic dependence on Chinese inputs is greater now than when the 2005 agreement was signed, and the military asymmetry is there to see. Therefore, insistence on the perfect format from a weakening position may end up getting neither the desired format nor a settlement.

Delhi appears to have judged that partial progress now is better than a comprehensive deal later. And yet, India must insist on three things in its approach to China going forward. One, the pre-2020 status quo has to stay on the table as an Indian demand

that will not be given up under any circumstances, without consigning it to the general commitment to peace and tranquillity. For this is a must, not a wish. So, the item on de-escalation must be brought back into the text at the 26th round next year.

Two, the Expert Group's terms of reference should not confine themselves to the easier sectors. Limiting progress to Sikkim and the middle sector (if indeed that is the case) would not be enough to cater to Indian interests on the LAC. Delhi must spell out what it understands by "Early and Substantial Harvest", and ensure that the earliness and substance extend to the other sectors as well.

Third, India must maintain constant vigilance and active military presence along the LAC, refusing to lower its guard for vague paper commitments.

Past agreements have repeatedly broken down, and future ones remain vulnerable to the same fate, so it is imprudent to let the improvement in the paperwork be mistaken for an improvement on the ground. Ultimately, robust deterrence is the only true guarantee of peace.

Happymon Jacob is founder & director, Council for Strategic and Defence Research, editor, *INDIA'S WORLD* magazine. The views expressed are personal

{ RAJNATH SINGH } DEFENCE MINISTER

Developed India does not mean only big projects and modern buildings ... (it) also means that children get good education, clean water reaches family homes...

{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }

Shashi Shekhar

India's gig workers need more effective protection

This incident happened just before Rakshabandhan: The security personnel stationed at the society gate, called to inform that the *mehndi* dhadhi (henna artist) had arrived. My daughter had scheduled his services through an app for 8.30 in the evening, but he was running two hours late. When we opened the door, an overworked, exhausted man stood in front of us. We could see he was in no position, physically or mentally, to perform this delicate task. My daughter offered him water and asked why he was so late.

Buckling under the emotional weight he had been carrying, he said, "Madam, since morning, none of the clients adhered to the appointment timing, so work starts late and finishes late. I can't say anything because they can complain or, worse, give a bad rating. Based on the feedback, the company can block me."

"I am on the bike all day long for my commutes, get stuck in traffic jams, and wade through water-logging. The company wants everything on time, but it's not in my hands. When I used to work in the village, the earnings were less but people respected me. Now it seems I have turned into a machine. I don't have a home, and I don't have a family. The next day's first booking was again at 8.30 am."

Our metropolises have turned into mirages. The same day, I read that, buoyed by the start of the festive season, companies have initiated hiring of gig workers. Companies providing such workers think that this year, 2.5-3 lakh new jobs can be created. They are expecting an increase in hiring by 8-15%.

This trend isn't restricted to metropolitan cities. Small towns and even the interiors need more hands. But such hiring is transient. The moment festive demand subsides, the jobs will vanish too.

Companies hiring gig workers operate on the principle of "use and throw". No one is sacked but are removed using technical grounds. As soon as festive and discount seasons of big companies end, incentives for the delivery partners are discontinued. Their app, using technical jargon, blocks their ids. This trend has dealt a body blow to the humane side of employment.

Even those constantly engaged in earning a living are subjected to inhuman stress. Pres-

sure of delivering on time has led to accidents in some cases. According to Niti Aayog, 27% of the gig workers in India face accidents (minor or serious). Muscle pain and other issues due to long hours, including driving with heavy loads, is a common problem. Treatment is long and expensive and demands rest. However, if you don't log into the app for a long period, you run the risk of being locked out.

Still, gig workers are increasing by the day. According to the Niti Aayog, in 2021, there were 77 lakh gig workers in India. In the last four years, this workforce has registered a whopping 55% increase. Niti estimates that, in the next four years, the numbers will reach 23 crore — 67% of the non-agriculture workforce. Nearly 22% of this workforce is concentrated in the National Capital Region. Today, apart from the marquee apps, there are many regional apps that cater to demand in the interiors and hills. This new work culture has changed the face of the Indian labour market. Sparkling uniforms, clean taxis or bikes, and direct bank transfers for quick payment look quite attractive from a distance. But it is the illusion of formalisation — it has severed the human cord that held humans and their work together. Earlier, there was a personal touch between the employer and the employee. Today, labour management is hijacked by opaque algorithms.

Gig workers also act as useful tools to hide actual unemployment. Many times, people with higher education degrees turn to this work in the absence of any credible employment. They don't want to be labelled as unemployed. Another dark side of the whole affair is the critical shortage of workers it is creating in agriculture and small industries. There's a huge social angle to too. Unemployed young don't want to do "small jobs" near their homes or their villages. Instead, they head to big cities and work under inhuman conditions.

It's clear that problems for gig workers are piling up faster than the rate at which gig workers are increasing. It's time that we make tough laws and regulations to safeguard gig workers' economic and social security, like Europe has. Rajasthan has shown the way. It's time for the Centre and other states carried the torch.

A progressive society runs on policies and regulations, not on algorithms.

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, *Hindustan Times*. The views expressed are personal

Gulf rulers should confront their real enemy: Khamenei

Reuters

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DUBAI/CAIRO: Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei urged Muslim countries, particularly those in the Gulf, to unite against what he called their "real enemy" and said divisions among Muslims served the interests of their adversaries.

The message was published on Khamenei's Telegram account for Islamic Unity Week, which marks the birthday of the Prophet Muhammad.

It called for Muslim unity, cooperation in various fields and mutual defence, saying anyone who creates divisions among Muslims, "knowingly or unknowingly," helps Islam's enemies. It asked whether Palestinians would have been left "so helpless" if Muslims had been united. Khamenei has not been seen in public since being injured in US-Israeli airstrikes six months ago that launched the Iran war, killing his father and previous supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

His call for unity echoes a statement he made on Friday to Iranians, when he said he had banned actions that harm social cohesion and urged authorities to avoid "discouraging statements" that weaken national and public morale. Khamenei specifically asked Gulf Arab rulers whether "rogues without identity" would have dared to covet their lands and possessions if the Gulf had been "united under the flag of Islam." "My emphatic and repeated recommendation to the rulers of Islamic countries, especially the countries of West Asia and the Gulf, is to identify your real enemy, understand his plan and confront it," Khamenei said.



Ruins of the girls' elementary school in Minab on August 27. REUTERS

Turkey, Saudi, Pak to hold first Mecca defence pact meet

Reuters

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ISTANBUL: Top officials from Turkey, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan will gather in Istanbul on Monday for a first committee meeting under the joint defence accord that they signed this month, a Turkish foreign ministry source said.

The "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement", signed on August 7, brought together Sunni Muslim US allies concerned by the Iran war that has led to Iranian missile fire on Gulf oil exporters.

It stipulates that an armed attack against any of the three would be regarded as an attack on all, similar to Nato's Article 5 collective defence clause.

Foreign and defence ministers, as well as the chiefs of staff, of the three countries will attend the meeting in Istanbul, the ministry source said.

"International security issues will be on the agenda," the source said, with discussions expected to cover enhancing defence capabilities, greater interoperability among their armed forces and deepening cooperation in the defence industry, including joint production and development. The three nations share concerns as long-time ally the US struggles to contain regional upheaval that has caused a global energy crisis.

Turkey, which has Nato's second-largest military, has said the pact with nuclear-armed Pakistan and top oil exporter Saudi Arabia was open to expansion.

B'desh, China to step up defence ties

Rezaul H Laskar

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NEW DELHI: Bangladesh and China on Sunday signalled their intention to cooperate on a project to manage the Teesta river and to launch a new strategic dialogue between their foreign ministers as well as a diplomacy and defence dialogue.

The moves are unlikely to go down well in New Delhi, especially at a time when Dhaka is yet to respond to the Indian side's invitations to Prime Minister Tarique Rahman for a bilateral visit and participation in the upcoming Brics Summit.

The Teesta is one of the 54 trans-boundary rivers for which India and Bangladesh are yet to conclude a water-sharing agreement. Concerns have grown on the Indian side over recent discussions between Bangladesh and China, including during Rahman's first major overseas trip to China in June, on cooperation on the Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration Project.

The cooperation on the Teesta



Chinese ambassador Yao Wen with Bangladesh minister Humairun Kobir in Dhaka on Sunday. BANGLADESH MOFA-X

and the new two dialogue mechanisms figured at a meeting in Dhaka on Sunday between Chinese ambassador Yao Wen and Bangladesh minister of state for foreign affairs Humairun Kobir, a key aide of Rahman.

"The two sides, discussed a wide range of issues of mutual interest, including cooperation on the Teesta River Comprehensive Management and Restoration, the early launching of a

Foreign Minister-level Strategic Dialogue, and the beginning of State Minister-level Diplomacy and Defence Dialogue," Bangladesh's foreign ministry said.

India's concerns about cooperation between Bangladesh and China on the dredging and desilting of the Teesta river largely centre round the possibility of Chinese personnel gaining access to areas close to the so-called "chicken's neck" or

slender piece of territory linking India's strategic northeastern states to the rest of the country.

The move to launch the Bangladesh-China diplomacy and defence dialogue comes close on the heels of Dhaka's decision to buy Chinese 4.5-generation J-10CE fighters. Zayed Ur Rahman, information and defence casting adviser to the Bangladesh PM, said last week that a draft proposal to buy the J-10CE jets, Chinese attack helicopters, VIP transport copters and UAV systems were submitted for final approval.

Bangladesh media reports said the country could acquire 20 J-10CE combat jets for \$2.3 billion. Zayed Ur Rahman said the J-10CE's performance during the India-Pakistan conflict of May 2025 was one of the factors that influenced Dhaka's decision. Pakistan reportedly used J-10CE jets equipped with active electronically scanned array (AESA) radars and PL-15 long-range air-to-air missiles to target India's Rafale fighters. Zayed Ur Rahman claimed the J-10CE "performed better in head-on

combat". During the meeting with the Chinese ambassador, Kobir described China as a "trusted friend and valued strategic partner of Bangladesh" and reaffirmed Dhaka's commitment to the One-China Principle.

Kobir also expressed satisfaction at the renewed momentum in bilateral relations and the elevation of ties to a "China-Bangladesh Community with a Shared Future" following PM Rahman's recent visit to China.

Yao briefed Kobir on the groundbreaking of the China Economic and Industrial Zone (CEIZ), the signing of a commercial contract for modernising Bangladesh's Mongla port, and possible cooperation on establishing the Mongla Export Processing Zone (EPZ). CEIZ is expected to attract investments of about \$500 million from around 30 Chinese companies, and create an estimated 100,000 jobs for Bangladeshis, Yao said. The two sides also discussed the China-Bangladesh-Myanmar Economic Corridor and cooperation on the Rohingya issue, the statement said.

TRUMP: WILL USE VENEZUELAN OIL TO REFILL U.S. STRATEGIC RESERVE

Reuters

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WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump said on Sunday that oil from a recently struck deal with Venezuela will be used to replenish the Strategic Petroleum Reserve, which has been drawn down sharply in recent years to respond to global supply disruptions and high fuel prices.

Trump said in a social media post that the "topping out" process will begin shortly, describing the Venezuelan oil as a "Gift from Venezuela to the People of the United States."

It is unclear how quickly the Venezuela deal could provide oil for the reserve or deliver any near-term benefit to US motorists.

World mostly shrugs off US's Iran curbs threat

Bloomberg

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WASHINGTON/ISTANBUL/ABU DHABI: Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent began last week vowing an "economic onslaught" against Iran and its trading partners in a fresh bid to end the war. By week's end, countries with ties to Tehran had so far shrugged off the threat and analysts were left underwhelmed by the US actions.

China, which buys 90% of Iran's oil, issued a defiant warning to Washington rather than back down. Iranian bank branches remained open in Dubai. At one Bank Mellat branch in Abu Dhabi, staff were busy typing away and one employee explained that they were still open for business.

Commercial flights also continued between Iran and Turkey as well as Iran and the United Arab Emirates, which had promised last week to sever all trade and financial transactions with Tehran. Routes to Thailand and Azerbaijan, as well as multiple destinations in both Russia and China, were unaffected.

As the week came to a close, the US announced plans to sanction the UAE-based branches of Egypt's Banque Misr. That fell well below expectations after Bessent's warning that the world would see "a major announcement of a financial institution being sanctioned by the end of this week."

Bessent's threats — and the collective global shrug so far — underscore the Trump administration's main conundrum as it seeks to sanction Iran into meeting its demands.

Google Maps renames Lake Ontario in US

WASHINGTON: Google redesigned Lake Ontario as "Lake America" on maps seen by US users on Sunday after Donald Trump announced he was renaming the body of water.

People in Canada will still see Lake Ontario on their devices and computers, Google said. Google said it made its change in line with the US GNS, the official federal database for geographic names. It said those outside US and Canada will see both names.

Pak body slams use of excessive force against Pak people
LAHORE: Pakistan's human

rights body has said the state resorted to "disproportionate use of force" against protesters in the POK and raised serious questions about the credibility of poll process marred with violence. PTI

'We are standing firm', Maduro says in posts from NY jail
CARACAS: Venezuela's deposed leader Nicolas Maduro said on social media Sunday that he was "standing firm," while posting photographs from the New York prison where he has been held since his capture by US forces. "I am sending these photos as a small gift to all my grandchildren, to the boys and girls, and to all the good people who love us," he wrote on Telegram. AFP

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CEO exit adds pace to HDFC's succession

Shayan Ghosh

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MUMBAI: HDFC Bank was not expecting to start its new leadership hunt quite yet, but Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision to not seek a new term as chief executive when his tenure ends in October has suddenly put it in transition mode. Deputy managing director Kaizad Bharucha is widely expected to don the mantle of an interim chief till a full-time executive is found.

According to a person aware of the discussions, the bank will soon appoint a search firm to look for Jagdishan's replacement. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) typically wants banks to list a mix of external and internal candidate names for approval.

The person said the board had requested Jagdishan to reconsider his decision, but he declined. In his letter to the board, the chief executive said it had been six years since he took the top job and the bank had

made progress in technology, risk management, among other areas, the person said. Jagdishan also told the board that recent issues were behind them, the person added.

"For HDFC, this does not end the uncertainty but it perhaps the beginning, at least till a full-time CEO is not appointed," said Abhizer Diwani, founder of strategic advisory provider Neostart Advisors.

According to some people aware of the development, Jagdishan had got indications that the board was not keen on his reappointment or that he could get a truncated term, and his current term was set to end in just months' time. According to a second person aware of internal discussions, Jagdishan decided not to offer himself for reappointment because he did not want the ignominy of a shorter term, or worse, a rejection by RBI.

"Nobody clearly knows what RBI thinks on such issues and the central bank's stance is not



Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision to not seek new term as CEO when his tenure ends in Oct has put HDFC in transition mode. **MINT**

easy to gauge," the person said.

The bank, however, rejected these reasons for his sudden announcement. "The reasons cited by you for Mr Jagdishan not seeking a new term are totally false and inaccurate," a spokesperson for HDFC Bank said in response to emailed queries.

Widely expected to be the interim CEO, the 60-year-old Bharucha has spent 31 years at the bank and took on the role of

deputy managing director in April 2023. A commerce graduate from Sydenham College of Commerce and Economics, University of Mumbai, Bharucha has been at the bank since its inception.

Experts said Bharucha comes with a tenure constraint for the bank to consider him for the top job. RBI rules cap the total time an executive can serve as a whole-time director, including as managing director and chief

executive, at 15 years. Since Bharucha joined HDFC Bank's board in 2014, that would leave him only until 2029, giving him a relatively short runway as a full-time chief executive.

"Internally, deputy managing director Kaizad Bharucha can be recommended for managing director position—though (he) could get a shorter term due to RBI's rule of whole-time director max term of 15 years," said Anand Dama, executive director, head of banking and financial services research at Nuvama Institutional Equities.

This, said Dama, is an easy, faster and a pragmatic solution, which will provide the bank time to groom someone internally or externally, and lead to minimal business disruption. Jagdishan's slot is not the only top position the bank needs to fill. Proxy advisory firm Institutional Investor Advisory Services India Ltd (IIAS) said in a note on Sunday that HDFC Bank's leadership challenge is further complicated by other impending

India to sustain growth of 7% or more, says FM

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: The Indian economy has been growing at 7% or more after the Covid pandemic and it is expected to maintain the growth momentum despite global uncertainties, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman said while addressing the Indian diaspora in Chicago.

"Uncertainties, which are before every country, are only multiplying. We thought, we saw the worst when we went through Covid," she said, adding that India actually "recovered well" and since then it is sustaining the growth at 7% or more.

This year too, our growth will be at that range," she said, pointing at global uncertainties caused by two wars, tariff issues and the situation at the Strait of Hormuz disrupting global supplies of energy, fertilisers and other essential commodities.

The finance minister's statement came close on the heels of the Reserve Bank of India's latest growth projection on August 5. According to RBI, India's real gross domestic product (GDP) growth for 2026-27 is projected at 6.7%.

RBI increased latest GDP growth rate projection by 10 basis points from its June estimate as the economy weathered the storm generated by turbulent global geo-political environment, trade-related uncertainties, and an unpredictable monsoon in the first quarter of 2026-27.

Sitharaman said notwithstanding the breakdown of global energy and fertilizer supply chains, the government shielded its citizens. Despite the Hormuz crisis — which the finance minister termed as a "big challenge" — India kept itself as "well provisioned" to meet farmers' requirements of farmers without any additional cost and ensured energy is made available to every household. India imported nearly 80% of



Nirmala Sitharaman, Union finance minister. **ANI**

fertilisers it consumed through Hormuz that include urea, diammonium phosphate (DAP) and potash. She said. As a result, Indian farmers were left without fertilizers, which she recalled as an "unthinkable" situation. But the government arranged fertilisers from various different routes and the country is "adequately" stocked.

While the crisis has been managed, the government paid huge price to procure fertilizers for farmers from global suppliers. While the government continues to give urea at ₹300 per bag to Indian farmers while its procurement cost is ₹3,000 per bag, she said. "₹2,700 is the subsidy we give per bag of fertilizer," she said, adding that "there is no shortage" of fertilizer for farmers and no burden of the cost is shifted to them.

The finance minister said irrespective of global uncertainties, India is marching on the reform path with its focus on bilateral trade and investment cooperation with several economies and accelerating domestic engine of growth through capital investments for their multiplier effects. "So, reforms continue. We are also talking with several countries for bilateral investment treaty and also bilateral trade agreements because multi-lateral institutions are very slow..." she said.

NPCI to make UPI Auto-pay interoperable across apps

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The National Payments Corp. of India (NPCI) is set to make UPI AutoPay interoperable, allowing users to port recurring payment instructions across apps and merchants to move existing mandates from one payment gateway to another, four people aware of the development said.

The move could reduce two forms of lock-in in the recurring-payments market. Consumers will be able to shift existing AutoPay mandates to another UPI app instead of cancelling and recreating subscriptions, insurance premiums, systematic investment plans (SIPs) or loan repayments, while merchants will be able to move existing mandates to another payment provider when they switch gateways.

For users, a cross-app view

of mandates could also make it easier to track upcoming debits, account balances and forgotten subscriptions. Both features could be announced at the Global Fintech Fest in Mumbai next month, one of the people said.

Importantly, mandates linked to different customer bank accounts will continue to be debited from the account originally authorised by the user. The interoperability change instead allows eligible mandates to be accessed across UPI apps, while merchants can shift them to a new acquiring bank or payment gateway without requiring customers to register afresh.

NPCI launched UPI AutoPay in 2020 to let businesses automatically debit a customer's bank account at fixed intervals for subscriptions, loan payments, insurance premiums and mutual fund investments.



The move could reduce 2 forms of lock-in in the recurring-payments market. **MINT**

NPCI and payment gateways are working on interoperability to allow merchants to port mandates for acquiring partners for a while, the people cited above said.

The scale of recurring payments has also grown. NPCI data showed that the top 10 banks cumulatively processed nearly 1.8 billion UPI e-man-

date transactions in July, more than three times the \$85 million handled in July 2025.

The move is partly driven by smaller UPI apps, which see AutoPay as a tool that locks customers into larger rivals, like PhonePe or Google Pay. The change, however, requires work across the ecosystem. "All the apps also have to make changes to enable this, because it has to be across apps," the executive said, adding that his own company had made those changes.

Queries to NPCI didn't elicit any response till press time. For merchants, interoperability means their existing base of mandates becomes portable. Currently, a subscription business that switches payment gateways can route new customers through the new partner, but its older mandates provided, with the original provider.

SBI, SUBSIDIARY TO DILUTE UP TO 1% STAKE IN NSE

NEW DELHI: State Bank of India (SBI) and its subsidiary SBI Capital Markets Ltd together plan to dilute up to 1% stake in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) through the exchange's proposed ₹30,000-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The bank is participating in the NSE IPO and will dilute a 0.65% stake in the exchange. SBI Chairman C S Setty told PTI in an interview. "We are participating in that investment. We propose to divest 0.65% and 0.35% by SBI Capital Markets because both of us hold the stake. So together, about 1% as a stake," he said. SBI currently holds a 3.23% stake in the NSE, while SBI Capital Markets owns 4.33% in the country's largest stock exchange. **PTI**

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

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COUNTRY DELIGHT WARMS UP FOR \$200-300 MN IPO

Agnidev Bhattacharya & Priyamvada C.

agnidev.bhattacharya@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Country Delight's parent has begun early-stage preparations for an initial public offering (IPO) in India that could raise \$200-300 million, as the subscription-based dairy and fresh-produce delivery platform weaves a listing within the next 12-18 months, said two people familiar with the matter.

Bejaipur Dairy Pvt. Ltd. will begin informal pitches to investment bankers over the next 7-10 days to select lead managers for the proposed IPO, one of the people said. The IPO is likely to comprise a combination of fresh equity and an offer for sale by existing institutional shareholders, a second person said. The final issue size, primary-secondary split and timing will depend on the board's approval and stock market conditions, this person added.

They said that Country Delight is also evaluating a potential pre-IPO fundraise to establish a valuation benchmark before filing its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi). Both refused to be identified as the details are private.

An email query to Country Delight on August 28 did not elicit a response till press time. Started in 2015 by Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Indore graduates Chakradhar Gade and Nitin Kausal, the firm operates a direct-to-consumer supply chain for perishable food. The Gurugram-headquartered company sources milk, dairy products, fruits and vegetables directly from farmers and processing facilities and delivers them to urban households via an integrated supply network. Country Delight currently operates across metropolitan Delhi-NCR, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad and Chennai. Users place or modify subscription orders through its mobile app before midnight for early-morning delivery.

Country Delight has also expanded beyond its core subscription model. In late 2024, it entered quick commerce through a pilot offering 10-15-minute deliveries, putting it in competition with Blinkit, Zepto and Zepto Ltd.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

- ACROSS**
1. Transfer from two seasons say (10)
 8. One result of wool-gathering (5)
 9. Musical patron gives man first-class return (7)
 10. Chopped North Sea side for a liquorice flavor (7)
 11. Arrived from France for a match perhaps (5)
 12. Take revenge on someone as the climax to a joke (5-3)
 13. Not always brief (3-3)
 17. Instruction book? (5)
 19. Lower due to a disappointment? (3-4)
 21. Dan's involved with girl and both are in love (7)
 22. One dividing my wealth (5)
 23. Go in for vaulting now summer's here (6-4)

DOWN

2. Overweight boy's tie pulled out (7)
3. Inene ruined him (5)
4. Withdraw a direction to surrender (6)
5. Open a French quilt (7)
6. A claw that can pick up a pound in weight (9)
7. Notes kept in a pocketbook perhaps (5-5)
8. Yet they may be used when speaking blithely (5-5)
12. Women have warm regard for his wares (7)
15. Boat after exciting recount (7)
16. Work hard with an advertising jingle (6)
18. Girl is seen after the staff turns up (5)
20. The speed at which some work should be done (5)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17577)

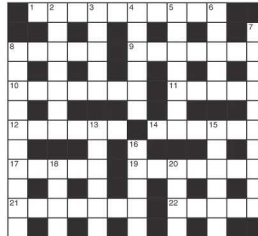
CRYPTIC

WREATH BRIOCH
 KAHN REUC
 LINTH TOWNEP
 GOUTOFBREATH
 RECOVER DELVE
 AAREO ORO
 CROISSANT
 ENTENKOR
 WAYLAYS EDISON

QUICK

GRATIS SKETCH
 DOWNHURU
 ORPNORGA
 WEDGE DOSSIER
 GUITTINGEDGE
 PUNDEBARCH
 FREDOLITE
 FLOWNSUBSIV
 RATHER ADONIS

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QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
1. Without preparation (3,4)
 8. Persistently harassed (5)
 9. The largest ape (7)
 10. Put at risk (7)
 11. Second planet from the sun (5)
 12. Thick soup (6)
 14. Group tightly (6)
 17. Sequence (5)
 19. Print and distribute (7)
 21. Expand (7)
 22. Half-hearted (5)
 23. On top of everything else (2,3,2)
- DOWN**
2. One who bothers about trivia (7)
 3. Private teacher (4)
 4. Swallow up completely (6)
 5. Disentangle (7)
 6. A criminal (5)
 7. Take up a cash collection (4,3,3)
 8. Show a profit (2,2,6)
 9. Relating to a class (7)
 10. Of little consequence (7)
 11. Maintenance (6)
 18. Apportion (5)
 20. To suit (5)

{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL: ★★ ★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.

WEATHER
 TEMPERATURE - HIGH - LOW

MONDAY
 Generally cloudy
 sky

TUESDAY
 Generally cloudy
 sky

WEDNESDAY
 Generally cloudy
 sky

28°C | 12°C **28°C | 21°C** **29°C | 22°C**

ALMANAC
 Today is 31st August 2026
 11th day of Aard, 14th of Kumbha, 03 of Sharad.

Sunrise: 05:41
Sunset: 18:04
Moonset: 01:00
 Moonrise: 06:59

TEMPERATURE IN METRO:

Delhi 35°C | 26°C
Mumbai 30°C | 27°C
Kolkata 30°C | 26°C
Chennai 34°C | 27°C
Bengaluru 28°C | 22°C



Ollie Robinson.
ROBINSON STRIKES AS ENGLAND SEAL PAKISTAN SERIES WIN AT LORD'S

Agencies
sportdesk@hindustantimes.com

LONDON: Ollie Robinson led the way once more as England clinched a series win over Pakistan with a thumping 194-run win in the second Test at Lord's on Sunday despite Saud Shakeel's fine 97. Pakistan were dismissed for 194, having been set a target of 389, to give England an unbeatable 2-0 lead in a three-match series.

This was England's first multi-match Test series win since a 2-1 success in New Zealand more than a year ago.

Robinson finished with figures of 4-24 in 14 overs following his sensational 4-11 in 13 during Pakistan's meagre first-innings 110 all out. The 30-year-old produced a pair of double strikes Sunday either side of Shakeel and Shan Masood checking England's progress with a fourth-wicket partnership of 97.

Robinson took two wickets in four balls to leave the tourists 7-2, before express quick Jofra Archer dismissed Pakistan captain Babar Azam. "It helps to have three (other) guys who bowl at 90 mph, it allows me to just dot up at one end and build the pressure," Robinson said. "It's quite a nice pairing (with Archer) to open the bowling, someone bowling that quickly and swinging the ball the other way from me. Long may it continue."

Brief scores: England 290 & 208, Pakistan 110 & 194 all out (Saud Shakeel 97, O Robinson 4-24, J Tongue 3-46). **England won by 194 runs.**

From despair to defiance, Tilottama eyes Asiad glory

After missing the 2023 Asian Games and 2024 Paris Olympics, the rifle shooter is keen to shine in Japan

Shantanu Srivastava
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NEW DELHI: At 18, Tilottama Sen has already experienced the microcosm of an athlete's life. Having missed the 2023 Hangzhou Asian Games after finishing third in the selection trials, she bounced back with silver at the Asian Championships that year, securing a 10m air rifle quota for the Paris Olympics. She missed out on Paris too, despite having won the quota (it belongs to the country).

Three years is a long time in elite sport, and Tilottama has used it to turn things around. She calls herself the "pampered baby of the team", but has navigated the highs and lows that typify an athlete's arc with a maturity that belies her age.

About to represent India in her first Asian Games (Sept 19-Oct 4) in the 50m 3 Positions event, the teenager is a bundle of nervous excitement.

"This will be my first multi-discipline event and I am really looking forward to it. The experience of meeting so many high-quality athletes, competing in a truly world class field, and the chance to win a medal for your nation is all a little overwhelming. I am determined to give my best," she told HT.

"It's a bit of a full circle moment for me. I was heartbroken after missing out on the last Asian Games. I was only 15 then, so you can imagine my state. But missing the Paris berth

AGE
18

EVENT
50M 3P
(P: Positions)

Teen Spirit

Shooter **Tilottama Sen** aims to set aside the disappointment of missing the 2023 Asian Games and 2024 Paris Olympics on her Asiad debut next month. Here's a lowdown:

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS (10m rifle)

BRONZE ISSF World Cup 2023, Cairo	SILVER Asian C'ships 2023, Changwon
---	---

4th At ISSF World Championships 2023, Baku
(Note: Individual events only)

DOMESTIC SUCCESS

50m 3P GOLD Senior Women	10m Air Rifle GOLD Junior Women
50m 3P GOLD National Selection Trials (T1, T2, T3)	10m Air Rifle GOLD National Selection Trials (T1)

despite winning the quota was a bigger disappointment."

What followed after the intense selection trials in the lead-up to Paris was a break from shooting and a chance to familiarise with the 50m 3P event. She locked away her rifle and withdrew from the sport. Family's pep talk, phone calls with fellow shooters Rudranksh Patil and Divya TS, and sessions with the psychologist did help, and gradually the angst gave way to determination.

"Shooting is an extremely individual sport and hence it takes a lot of you. I realised I didn't have the energy to shrug off the disappointment and bounce back

quickly. But eventually, you get up," she recalled.

By the time 2025 arrived, Tilottama regained her bearings and returned to the shooting range. That's when national rifle coach Manoj Kumar suggested she try the 50m event.

"I almost hated the 10m event, so I was all up for the new challenge," she laughs. Widely considered a tougher rifle event, the 50m discipline uses a .22 calibre small-bore rifle, firing bullets rather than the pellets used in 10m air rifle. The competition is outdoors, making wind and weather additional variables for the shooters to deal with.

"I'd say it is a technically superior event. It tests you physically but gives you a chance to come back. If you are good at 50m, chances are you'll get better at 10m also," she said.

At the start of 2025, Tilottama travelled to a Waltham unit in Germany for equipment testing (10m air rifle) and met Heinz Reinke-meier, who coached Abhinav Bindra to the 10m air rifle gold at the 2008 Beijing Olympics.

"I had a month-long clinic with him and we basically broke down my game in 10m event. It was like starting all over again. We worked on the basics and I gradually found my way back," she said. Back home, 50m took precedence over air rifle. Tilottama won the 2025 senior Nationals title in 50m while cruising through the junior and youth categories in 10m, finishing the championships with 12 medals across events and age groups.

This year, she won a 10m air rifle trial (T1) and went on to win three on the trot in the 50m to underline her dominance. Three years after watching the Hangzhou Asian Games from the sidelines, she has finally earned her chance.

"It's time to convert this form into an Asiad medal. I have never shot in Japan, but once I enter the range, it's just me and the target," she said. "I have seen how a good Asian Games can change the course of your career. We saw it with Saur (Kaur Samra) and Esha (Singh) the last time.

"I hope it's my turn now."

Germany clinch record-equalling fourth World Cup

Agencies
sportdesk@hindustantimes.com

WAVRE (BELGIUM): Defending champions Germany produced a disciplined defensive display to edge Spain 1-0 in the FIH Men's Hockey World Cup final and draw level with Pakistan's record of four titles.

Germany had previously won the World Cup in Kuala Lumpur in 2002, Mönchengladbach in 2006 and Bhubaneswar in 2023. Pakistan's four titles came in 1971, 1978, 1982 and 1994. Spain, meanwhile, made their first World Cup final appearance since 1998 and their third overall, but its wait for a maiden title continued.

In front of around 8,000 spectators at the Belfius Hockey Arena both teams displayed excellent defence and consistently thwarted each other's attempts.

The only goal of the match was scored by Germany's Michel Struthoff in the 44th minute in run of play.

After a goalless first half, Spain launched ten attacks on the German goal in the third quarter, but Germany prevailed. In the first fifteen minutes, both teams earned a penalty corner each, but failed to achieve success. Germany attacked first and earned a penalty corner in the second minute, but Benedikt Schwarzhaupt's shot was saved by the Spanish goalkeeper. Spain's Borja Lallue failed to counterattack in the ninth minute.

In the first quarter, Germany dominated possession, while Spain relied on short passes and good coordination in the second quarter but failed to provide the finishing touch.

Spain's Joaquin Menini passed the ball to Iñaki Zaldua inside the circle in the 18th minute who lost the possession. Three minutes later, Spain's Nicolas Alvarez advanced alone from the right flank through the middle of the field but lost control inside the D. Germany had a golden opportunity to score two minutes before the break when Grobe Johannes received the ball on the left side of the goal and passed it to Teo Hinrichs but his shot was blocked. The ball landed inside the circle, hit Justus Weigand's stick, and then went back to Grobe but he failed to aim accurately.

In the 44th minute, Germany scored their first goal from open play, demonstrating excellent coordination from the flanks. Michel received the ball from the right and, with the Spanish goalkeeper out of position, easily deflected it into the net.



Germany players celebrate after winning the World Cup.

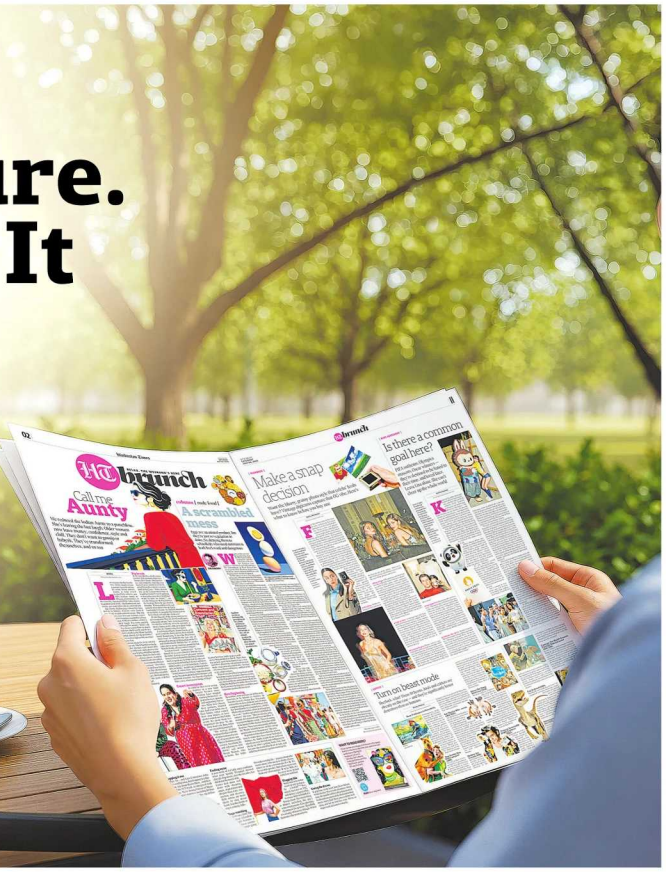
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Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending. It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



HT

Bruno hat-trick lifts United vs Ipswich

LONDON: Bruno Fernandes scored a hat-trick in Man United's 5-2 rout of Ipswich, while Chelsea extended Nabil Alonso's perfect start with a thrilling 4-3 win against Brighton. Fernandes's dynamic display ensured United bounced back from their humiliating 2-0 defeat at Hull on the opening game. Michael Carrick's side were in danger of another loss to a promoted club when Lee Davis put Ipswich ahead in the 29th minute.

Bellingham, Mbappe fire for Real Madrid

MADRID: Jude Bellingham and Kylian Mbappe both struck as Real Madrid's La Liga perfect start to La Liga under Jose Mourinho continued in a 4-0 cruise against Malaga. Los Blancos scored three times in just over 10 minutes in the first half at the Santiago Bernabeu. Sandwiched between Bellingham and Mbappe's strikes was an own goal by Malaga goalkeeper Alfonso Herrero, while Arda Guler tapped in a fourth late on.

Augib Nabi to play 3 matches for Surrey

MUMBAI: Augib Nabi for the UK to play three games for Surrey in the County Championship Division One with an eye on India's tour of New Zealand in October. The J&K pacer was recently drafted into the Indian squad as a replacement for the injured Jasprit Bumrah in the two-T20 series in Sri Lanka but did not get a chance to make his debut.

Abhay Singh wins 13th PSA Tour title

NEW DELHI: Top seed Abhinav Bindu clinched the Tianshui Muirby Trophy squash event in Malaysia defeating third seed Henry Leung of Hong Kong 11-7, 6-11, 3-11, 12-10 to bag his 13th PSA Tour title.

SL lose hosting rights of Champions Trophy

COLOMBO: ICC has taken away hosting rights of the inaugural edition of the Women's Champions Trophy to be held in 2027 from Sri Lanka due to government interference in the administration of Sri Lanka Cricket.

Indian tours add to funding cycles, says NZC CEO Allott

Rasesh Mandani
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MUMBAI: Cricket fans may remember Geoff Allott as the joint-leading wicket-taker of the 1999 ODI World Cup. After retirement, the former New Zealand left-arm pacer combined his commerce and management skills and entrepreneurial skills to set up a F&B and education business in India before serving in New Zealand Cricket (NZC). The India experience will hold him in good stead to steer NZC out of choppy waters as he serves as CEO, a job he took over in April. Earlier this month, NZC announced a revenue deficit of \$7.3 million for FY 26. Allott took over with the objective of creating new revenue streams to turn the balance sheet around. In recent interviews to local media, he has spoken of budgeting errors of broadcast revenue to the tune of \$5 million as the main reason for the deficit. Allott said that the fantasy league partner Dream II (after its fall following India's gambling law changes) has also hurt. So, in an inbound India tour, a silver series being potentially a big part of how New Zealand Cricket operates, and when India tours, that flows directly into our international broadcast deals," Allott told HT. "We're also funded by ICC, alongside our own commercial partners, sponsors and gate receipts, but it is fair to say that Indian tours contribute significantly to our funding cycles."

An all-format India tour of New Zealand comes after six years - India toured for a white-ball series in 2022-23 and the series in October-November could not have been better timed for the host board. Allott calls the India series "an incredible occasion" and "a celebration of our two countries".

With the five-match T20 series being a renewal of rivalry between this year's World Cup finalists, the two-match Test series being potentially decisive in the World Test

Rutvik Mehta
rutvik.mehta@ht.com

MUMBAI: It is Arthur Ashe Kids' Day at the US Open. Jordan Manlapig, a 39-year-old American resident, is at one of the practice courts hosting women's world No.1 Aryna Sabalenka, four-time Grand Slam champion Naomi Osaka and men's world No.2 Alexander Zverev.

Someone else's hitting session, though, attracts the biggest crowd for the day - Alexandra Eala. "That says a lot about her star power," Manlapig, whose parents are Filipino, told HT from New York. Manlapig is part of a large Filipino community in New York that has flocked to Flushing Meadows over the last week to catch a glimpse of one of their own. A tennis professional from The Philippines is rare enough, a world No.18 in women's singles even more so.

And yet, Eala's rocketing star power isn't just fuelled by the Filipino community or confined to The Philippines. Over the past few months, the 21-year-old has filled stadiums worldwide and swelled countless views like only a handful of women have in the history of tennis. In Washington at a WTA 500 tournament, around 80% of the ticket enquiries were for Eala's matches, according to the tournament chairman. Top seed Jessica Pegula, whom the southpaw beat to become the first Filipino to win a WTA title, said it was "the best Monday final crowd" she had ever seen. Playing her next match in Toronto, Eala drew a sellout crowd on a Wednesday.

In New York, Eala's entry into a packed Arthur Ashe Stadium for the Stars of the Open event had a concert vibe to it. The video of her match with Evie Jones in his 18 lakh views on YouTube. For context, the match of Leander Tien, an exciting US prospect, and French Open runner-up Flavio Cobelli, has 15 lakh views.

Manlapig has followed Eala since she won the US Open girls' singles title in 2022 (again, the first Filipino to do so). He waited in line for three hours at the 2025 Australian Open for her match, and watched Eala beat Osaka and Pegula in Washington.

"I've been a huge fan behind Eala's soaring popularity is a Filipino value called 'kapwa', which roughly means shared identity, as he puts it. "When Alex accomplishes something like winning a

'Kapwa' that binds Eala, the Philippines and stardom

Alexandra Eala

Age: 21 | Country: The Philippines

CAREER WIN-LOSS RECORD

● Won ● Lost

232 369 PLAYED 137

KEY FACTS

Breakout 2025 season saw her enter the Top 100 after the semi-final run at WTA 1000 in Miami

As a wild card she registered back-to-back Top 10 wins, over No.5 Madison Keys and No.2 Iga Swiatek

Went on to reach maiden Tour final at Eastbourne and then won her first WTA 125 title in Guadalajara

She is the first player from the Philippines to reach a WTA 1000 semi-final and the first to enter the WTA Top 100 ranking

ALA'S RANKING GRAPH IN 2026

(Her 2025 year-end ranking was a career high No.50)

RANKING

53 40 29 42 30 28

JAN 5, 2026 FEB 9, 2026 MAR 16, 2026 MAY 4, 2026 JUN 22, 2026 JUL 27, 2026 AUG 31, 2026

match, it's a modern example of kapwa, in which we take pride that one of our own has accomplished a feat on the world stage," said Manlapig. "Essentially, we secure ourselves in her."

Eala, too, feels that sense of "kapwa." "I think a reason also why I have such a big following is because people see themselves in me," she said on Served with Andy Roddick podcast.

Extremely eloquent for her age, Eala has spoken about understanding the values and culture she represents. Tennis culture was as distant in the land of Manny Pacquiao as The Philippines is in the sport's landscape. What began as a way to bond with her grand-

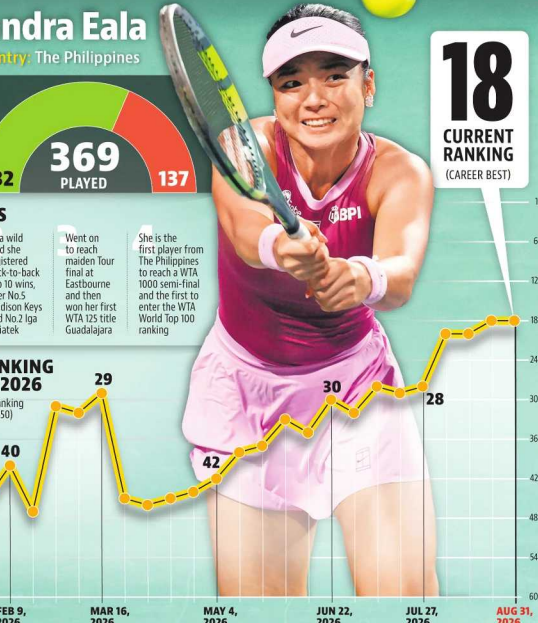
father turned into a possible career pathway for Eala. One in which nobody had walked before in her country. "There's not a lot of tennis players in The Philippines, something I'd hope would change in the near future... So, for me, it was something I had to take step by step, and so many things my family and I had to learn on our own."

Eala said this at the Mumbai Open last February, when, in contrast to being the cynosure of world media in a Grand Slam, she was speaking to a crowd of reporters at a WTA 125K event. Even then, as a highly-rated trainee of the Rafa Nadal Academy, where she entered in 2018, she carried some spotlight. Even then, she knew what it meant.

"It's such a big privilege to have this support, and this, quite unique, spotlight," Eala said, standing by the CIJ courts. "Especially the support I get from home, from the Filipino people, it's such a blessing. Because I know that not a lot of people in this ranking space are able to get that."

Eala was then outside the top 125. After making the 2025 Miami Open semi-final, winning her first Slam match at the 2025 US Open and reaching the Round of 16 at the 2025 Wimbledon, she is now in the top 20. The stardom surge has been even more gigantic than the rankings rise.

Eala is not just a presence in tennis at the moment. She is a phenomenon.



Jessica Pegula during her match against Elena Gabriela Ruse. REUTERS

Pegula shakes off nerves to win opening match

Agencies
sportstimes@hindustantimes.com

NEW YORK: Third-ranked Jessica Pegula shook off nerves that contributed to a slow start against Elena-Gabriela Ruse, winning her opening match at the US Open on Sunday in straight sets.

Leading off at Arthur Ashe Stadium, the 32-year-old American missed her first nine opportunities to break Ruse but found a rhythm and began dominating. Coming off a trip to the final at the Cincinnati Open, which she lost to Coco Gauff, Pegula won 92% of her first serve points on the way to a 6-3, 6-2 victory in 83 minutes.

Pegula saved the only break point she faced, but her nerves showed as she converted just two of her 14 break point chances in the opening set.

"I was so nervous," Pegula said. "I was like sending GIFs of what I felt like. It was GIFs of people freaking out and stuff... The first round of a Slam, there's always a ton of nerves."

That was enough, and she was an efficient two-for-four on break opportunities in the second set. She gave herself triple match point with a crisp forehand winner to the corner and after Ruse saved two with booming serves secured the win when the Romanian put a fore-

hand into the net.

With the first round now spread over three days, Pegula was looking forward to a couple of days off with a confidence-boosting win under her belt.

"I get to sit around the site and watch everybody else break out for the next two days," she said.

Pegula next faces the winner of the match between Venus Williams and fellow wild card Sofia Kenin.

Nineteenth-seeded Jasmine Paolini also advanced in women's singles, defeating Veronika Erjavec 6-3, 3-6, 6-4. Kamilla Rakhimova beat No. 27 seed Barbora Krejickova 7-6 (4), 6-2.

Injured Raul pults out Casper Rud, the 2022 US Open runner-up, withdrew from the tournament because of a back injury. Rud was forced to stop playing in his first match in the recent Cincinnati Open. He played in the mixed doubles tournament in Flushing Meadows, but was seen in videos struggling to serve in practice.

Rud, who is ranked No. 20, was replaced in the draw by Arup Sharma - led the final round of qualifying. He will face Juan Manuel Cerundolo in the first round.

Rud lost to Carlos Alcaraz in the 2022 US Open final.

DPL: South Delhi emerge champions

HT Correspondent

sportstimes@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Delhi Premier League saw a new winner crowned in its third edition as South Delhi Superstars emerged champions on Sunday.

The Tejasvi Dahiya-led outfit defeated Central Delhi Kings by seven wickets in the final at the Arun Jaitley Stadium.

"As a league, we're very happy with the quality of cricket, the quality of skill, the talent, the new faces that are coming out. The names that were not known till about four weeks ago have now become a known name, at least within the city of Delhi," said DCA President Rohan Jaitley on the success of the league.

"The Apex Council of the association are parents to this tournament. And now it's grown up, it's reaching some mature stages. And when we see this response, we are really proud of ourselves that the association has done something, and the owners of all the franchises especially have some faith in us and that we're doing the right thing. And what we see here with the players outdoing themselves, showing what they have to offer," he added.

Each time one would ask a South Delhi Superstars player



DCA President Rohan Jaitley (l) presents the DPL champions trophy to South Delhi Superstars captain Tejasvi Dahiya as DCA secretary Ashok Sharma (from left), league commissioner Bimal Julka and DCA joint secretary Amit Grover look on, at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Sunday.

what their goals were for the season, they would respond with a simple answer - get the trophy home this time. Boasting one of the most star-studded line-ups since the first edition, Superstars had missed out on the trophy in the first edition, finishing runners-up.

This time around, the mission was complete thanks to an all-round show from Divansh Rawat and Anmol Sharma, Ankit Dabur and Tejasvi Dahiya. Pacer Rawat starred with the ball, claiming 37 - finishing the tournament with a total of 14 wickets in nine matches.

He accounted for the wickets of opener Samarth Singh (51), Keshav Dabas (33) and Vansh Bedi (11). Samarth, Yugal Sinha (32) and captain Jyoti Sidhu (36) played vital knocks but the innings lacked a solid finish as Central Delhi were wrapped up for 182/8.

Despite losing Pranav Pant early, South Delhi Superstars looked like they always had



Jessica Pegula during her match against Elena Gabriela Ruse. REUTERS

Pegula shakes off nerves to win opening match

Agencies
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NEW YORK: Third-ranked Jessica Pegula shook off nerves that contributed to a slow start against Elena-Gabriela Ruse, winning her opening match at the US Open on Sunday in straight sets.

Leading off at Arthur Ashe Stadium, the 32-year-old American missed her first nine opportunities to break Ruse but found a rhythm and began dominating. Coming off a trip to the final at the Cincinnati Open, which she lost to Coco Gauff, Pegula won 92% of her first serve points on the way to a 6-3, 6-2 victory in 83 minutes.

Pegula saved the only break point she faced, but her nerves showed as she converted just two of her 14 break point chances in the opening set.

"I was so nervous," Pegula said. "I was like sending GIFs of what I felt like. It was GIFs of people freaking out and stuff... The first round of a Slam, there's always a ton of nerves."

That was enough, and she was an efficient two-for-four on break opportunities in the second set. She gave herself triple match point with a crisp forehand winner to the corner and after Ruse saved two with booming serves secured the win when the Romanian put a fore-

hand into the net.

With the first round now spread over three days, Pegula was looking forward to a couple of days off with a confidence-boosting win under her belt.

"I get to sit around the site and watch everybody else break out for the next two days," she said.

Pegula next faces the winner of the match between Venus Williams and fellow wild card Sofia Kenin.

Nineteenth-seeded Jasmine Paolini also advanced in women's singles, defeating Veronika Erjavec 6-3, 3-6, 6-4. Kamilla Rakhimova beat No. 27 seed Barbora Krejickova 7-6 (4), 6-2.

Injured Raul pults out Casper Rud, the 2022 US Open runner-up, withdrew from the tournament because of a back injury. Rud was forced to stop playing in his first match in the recent Cincinnati Open. He played in the mixed doubles tournament in Flushing Meadows, but was seen in videos struggling to serve in practice.

Rud, who is ranked No. 20, was replaced in the draw by Arup Sharma - led the final round of qualifying. He will face Juan Manuel Cerundolo in the first round.

Rud lost to Carlos Alcaraz in the 2022 US Open final.

ASIA CUP: SHAFALI, SPINNERS HELP INDIA GET OFF TO SMOOTH START

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NEW DELHI: India started their T20 Asia Cup campaign in commanding fashion defeating Thailand by 94 runs in Dubai. Defending 160, spinners - especially Ravichandran Ashwin, who played a vital role in powering his team to the final with a 57 off 33 against the same opponent in Qualifier 1 along with leading the side since Ayush Badoni departed for the Duleep Trophy - stepped up. It's also worth noting that Superstars' in-form batter, Sanjay Sangwan, also joined North Zone at Duleep Trophy.

Dahiya was the most expensive buy at the auction this year after he was retained by Superstars for ₹40 lakh. He displayed some clean hitting to further add to Central Delhi Kings bowlers' agony. After he was dismissed by Garvish Khurana in the 18th over, Ekansh Dabur finished things off, chasing the target down in 18.2 overs.

Quarashi (2/49) picked up two wickets each. Rinku Singh (46 off 88), and Arjun Singh (46) were the top-scorers for Central. Central had lost half their side for 125 when Rinku Singh and Harsh Dube (27) stabilised the innings, stitching together 55 runs for the sixth wicket.

But once Dube was caught in plumb in front of Quarashi in the 60th over, Central's innings fell apart.

Suresh Jain (31) and Arpan Parag (22) got started but failed to capitalise.

Tail-end Yash Thakur (30 off 59) overtook his big brother to get Central's hopes forward, but the innings eventually folded inside the 300-run mark.

Brief scores: North 195 all out in 59.1 overs (Gurman Iqbal 76, Kanhaiya Wadhawan 35, Vidvath Kaveera 4/66, MD Nidheesh 2/36, Tanay Thyagarajan 2/31). South 40/2 (Rinku Singh 60, Arjun Singh 46, Abhinav Sarker 3/38, Mushkh Khan 3/56). **Matches to continue.**

Kaverappa bags four to help South bundle out North



South Zone players after the fall of a North wicket.

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BENGALURU: Karnataka pacer Vidvath Kaverappa's four-for helped South Zone dismiss North for 195 to take an upper hand on the opening day of their Duleep Trophy semi-final on Sunday.

Kaverappa bagged 4/66 while MD Nidheesh took 2/36 and opener Tanay Thyagarajan 2/31.

In reply, South were 40/2 at stumps. Anshul Kamboli (19) cleaned up Ricky Bhui (5) while Gurmeet Brar (1/22) pinned Shaik Rashed (0) in front to

give some respite to North, who are ahead by 155 runs. Narayan Jagadeesan, batting on 34 off 38 balls with six fours, was joined by skipper Tillet Varma.

Seamers had a field day at the BCCI CoE Ground 2 as they claimed eight of the 12 wickets to fall on the first day.

Mukesh, Sarkar shine Mukesh Kumar and fellow right-arm medium pacer Abhishek Sarker scalped three wickets apiece to help East bowl out Central for 266 in the other semi-final. Mukesh (3/56) and Sarkar (3/38) shared six wickets

while Mohammed Shami (2/42) and off-spinner Md Kounim Quarashi (2/49) picked up two wickets each. Rinku Singh (46 off 88), and Arjun Singh (46) were the top-scorers for Central.

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